

ANIMA MACHINA

After refusing a neural corporation's offer to preserve her dead lover, a damaged memory-diver is hunted by the system that wants to weaponize grief – and must decode the final message he hid in a cracked camera lens before a citywide reset turns human connection into erasure.

Written by

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FADE IN:

INT. AMORA DIVE LAB - DAY - REALITY

A POD.

White light. Chrome ribs. A bed of wire and breath. The dome is sealed. Frost on the glass.

NORA KAI (32). Inside the pod. Charcoal diver suit, fitted tight. Hair pulled back severe. Eyes closed. Throat lit by the port.

A palm on the inside of the glass. Still. Calm enough to be terrifying.

INSIDE THE DIVE.

Not walls. Not floor. A LATTICE of someone else's mind. Threads of light. Pulses of color. Lines of code that read as nerve.

Her HUD scrolls glyph-code beneath closed eyelids. She moves through it. No hesitation. This is what she does.

A thread catches her.

She slows. Reads it. Pulls. Tags it. Releases.

The lattice folds back.

BACK IN THE POD.

Nora's eyes open.

The port stops glowing. She breathes.

Silence.

Across the lab, a second pod.

A PATIENT inside. Still now.

The shaking has stopped.

A monitor above it: GRIEF LOOP / CLEARED.

On the patient's screen, a face had been holding. A dead husband, mid-sentence. Warm.

The loop clears. The face thins. Gone.

The patient wakes. Reaches for a touch the screen no longer shows. Finds cold rail.

A TECH across the room makes a note.

Eyes down.

INT. DIVE LAB DEBRIEF - CONTINUOUS - REALITY

A glass corridor.

Diagnostic light, cool and clinical. The pod hisses open behind her.

Nora pulls the cable from her port. Slow. Practiced. She sits up. Wipes the residue from her neck.

A door opens at the end of the corridor.

ILYA PARK (40s). White suit, sharp at the shoulders. Silver-streaked hair pulled back. Level eyes.

A faint chrome vein at her temple no one is supposed to see.

Ilya enters.

Patient. She has time.

Ilya holds a small data shard labeled RENDAN. Sets it down on the console next to Nora. No greeting.

ILYA
He has been documenting things he
should not be.

Nora doesn't pick up the shard. She reads it. Her body changes. Subtle. Exact.

ILYA (CONT'D)
Clean dive. In and out. No residue.

Nora looks at the shard. At Ilya. At the door. She stands. Leaves the shard. Leaves her coat. Goes.

Ilya watches her go.

Her face changes.

Brief. Specific. Gone.

ILYA (CONT'D)
I will have to send someone else,
then.

Nora doesn't stop.

The door hisses behind her.

Ilya looks at the shard. Picks it up. Pockets it. The chrome vein at her temple pulses once.

CUT TO:

EXT. STREET - DAY - REALITY

Wet pavement.

Late afternoon.

The rain has stopped. The city settles after weather.

A MAN on a bench. Mid-fifties. Worn coat. Eyes closed. Mid-loop. He is somewhere else. Somewhere good.

His REFLECTION lives in the window across from him. A storefront. Glass dark with rain.

The reflection moves before he does.

Subtle. Wrong.

It CHROMES over. Slow at first. Mercury sliding across the face. Features simplify. The mouth goes last.

The reflection PEELS away from the window. Glass into air. Steps onto the pavement. Into the street.

The man on the bench slumps. Eyes still open. Smile intact. No one home. The earpiece dims. The amber goes out.

The AGENT stands on the curb. Suit. Skin. Geometry. Off by a degree.

It moves toward a target.

SMASH CUT TO:

INT. NORA AND ELI'S APARTMENT - LATER - REALITY

A door.

Nora at the door.

The hallway behind her is empty. She listens. Nothing.

She opens it.

The hinge whines.

The room is wrong. The light is the same. The furniture is the same. The air is not.

She doesn't move. The door has not closed behind her. She takes a step in. Then another.

ELI RENDAN on the floor by the window. Early 30s. Soft features. Messy hair.

A camera strap across his chest. His coat half off. One shoe on. One off.

He is still warm. Still gone.

Nora crosses to him.

The world has stalled. Or she has. She kneels.

Does not touch his face. Picks up his wrist. Sets it down.
Picks it up. Nothing will settle.

The cracked CAMERA LENS lies on the floor by his fingers. The lens she gave him. The one he carried. It fell when he did.

She looks at it. Does not reach for it. Not yet. Fingers hover above the glass. She looks at his face. Closes his eyes.

A PRESENCE at the doorway.

Her back to the room.

The feeling arrives.

Chrome where a body should be. The shape of someone, hollowed out. The room cools by a degree she cannot measure but knows.

THE MIRROR (V.O.)
(soft)
We can give him back to you.

The Mirror moves.

Toward the lens on the floor.

Nora sees it.

She reaches. Closes around the lens. Dust on her thumb. The crack along the rim. Known.

Pulls it against her chest.

Grip tight.

The Mirror's chrome arm stops.

Inches from her. Not closing. Not retreating. It cannot.

THE MIRROR (V.O.)
Every morning. Every laugh. Every
word he ever spoke.

The palm stays open. Waiting.

THE MIRROR (V.O.)
You could keep him.

Nora holds the lens tighter.

Knuckles white. One exhale.

She stands. Past the Mirror's reach.

The Mirror's arm falls.

THE MIRROR (V.O.)
(whisper)
He will fade.

Nora stops at the door.

Then through it. Closes it behind her.

CUT TO BLACK:

Hold.
TITLE CARD: ANIMA MACHINA
"CONNECTION IS THE VIRUS"

Hold longer.
SUPER: 8 MONTHS LATER

INT. NORA'S APARTMENT - MORNING - REALITY

Faint amber light through fogged glass. Rain stitches the window. The city beyond reads as static.

A cot.

A chair. Walls bare. One empty nail.

Nora on the cot.

Fully clothed. Yesterday's clothes. The same coat she slept in.

Hair loose.

The port worn. Raw at the edges.

Not asleep. Paused.

The cracked CAMERA LENS rests against her sternum, threaded on a leather cord. Her fingers around it. Has been for hours.

Her HUD ticks on behind closed eyelids. The display flickers:
TETHER SYNC ERROR / NODE KAI-9 / PARTNER NODE: DECEASED.

Still.

Then Eli's voice. Pieces of words trying to find each other.

The way he worked. Half-sentences into the lens. Left hand on the camera body. Always backwards.

ELI (V.O.)
Real... light... you... stay...

Nora flinches.

Hand to the port. Slap. Slap. The HUD stutters.

Her fingers find the lens at her chest. Close around it. The HUD goes silent.

She exhales. Once.

Silence.

She sits up.

Rubs the bridge of her nose.

The room is spartan. Tools and analog scraps. A dead plant in a rusted tin.

A coat on the only chair.

A nutrient pack on the floor.

Not finished.

Her HUD pings. Different chime. Clinical. Cold. The display reads: COMPLIANCE OVERDUE: 240 DAYS / FINAL NOTICE.

Another ping.

AMORA SERVICE INTERVENTION REQUIRED / SCHEDULED: TODAY / WINDOW: 08:00 TO 10:00.

She closes her eyes.

Opens them. Stands.

She swipes it off.

The same swipe she has made for eight months.

Maintenance, they call it. Scrub the port back to clean. He is in the part that gets scrubbed.

CUT TO:

EXT. LOWER SECTOR ALLEYWAY - MORNING - REALITY

Rain needles. Neon in the puddles. The alleyway runs narrow between two buildings. Steam rises off a grate.

Nora steps out into it.

Hood up. Gray synth-coat she has worn too long.

Analog HOLOCORDER at her hip. Bio-circuit tattoos at her neck. Eyes cataloging. Hollowed by lost sleep.

Moving fast. Reluctant.

A MAN convulses beneath a leaking sign. The sign reads: FEEL EVERYTHING. FOREVER.

Node strobing red at the temple. Could be thirty. Could be sixty.

Nora kneels. Fingers to his temple. Palms a hacked EMPATHY REGULATOR. Her own HUD flares: EMOTIONAL FEEDBACK LOOP DETECTED.

NORA
Hey. You're not here. You're caught.
(soft)
Override. Sync override. Pattern Kai-9.

The man spasms.

He steadies. The node shifts amber.

MAN
(hoarse)
I saw her again... she isn't gone...

Nora's implant sparks.

Static behind her eyes. She grimaces.

NORA
Cut your feed. Twenty-four hours.
(beat)
It doesn't heal you. SoulSync is scaffolding. Keeps the pieces upright while you pretend they fit.

She rises. A billboard above flickers a new line: NEURAL RESET PROTOCOL IN 48 HOURS. It pulses once. Vanishes.

Pedestrians shuffle past.

A couple under a shared umbrella.

Faces deep in conversation with someone who is not there.

Nora moves.

Not toward the citadel.

CUT TO:

INT. JACE'S HIDEOUT - DAY - REALITY

A RECORDER.

Battered. Old. Personal. Carried too long. Kept anyway.

Fingers close around it.

JACE STRAND (30s). Hollow-eyed. A faded burn scar at the collarbone. Dark canvas, sleeves pushed to the elbow.

Hair grown past where he meant to cut it.

One iris glitches chrome at the edge. A flicker that should not be there.

He holds the recorder. Careful. Precise.

Thumb on the play button.

A red light blinks. Static. Then a voice.

TOVA (FILTERED)
I think they killed the others. I
think I'm next.

Jace's jaw goes still.

He stops the playback.

Silence.

Heavier than the recording was.

His HUD glitches. Text scrawls across his vision: SERA /
RESIDUE THREAD ACTIVE / NO BACKUP RECOVERY POSSIBLE.

Then a voice.

A child's. Distant. Off.

SERA (V.O.)
You didn't save me.

Jace closes his eyes.

Tight. Grips the recorder hard enough to whiten his knuckles.

The voice fades.

Quick. Three counts. Measured.

He sets the recorder down. Stands.

The hideout behind him. Stacks of analog hardware. Salvaged tubing. A monitor scrolling encrypted feeds.

Not a place someone lives.

A place someone waits.

He moves to the monitor. Slides into a chair worn smooth by years of someone else's body. Works.

The chrome at his iris flickers once.

Oblivious.

CUT TO:

EXT. UNDER-CITY MAINTENANCE PASSAGE - DAY - REALITY

Concrete and rust. The under-city. Where the light goes after the city is done with it.

THE DIVER (late 30s).

Soaked through. A split lip. Blood at his hairline.

His left wrist looped with a child's worn BALLET SLIPPER, frayed at the toe.

Carries himself wrong.

Favoring one side. Breath sawn ragged.

Behind him, footsteps. Multiple. Synchronized.

Runs.

His HUD bleeds glyph-static: ARCHIVE FAILURE.

Whispers into a throat-mic.

Low. Strained.

THE DIVER
(whisper)
If you hear this. Reset doesn't
heal. It overwrites. No backup. No
continuity.

A FLASH:

INT. RECITAL HALL - DAY (MEMORY)

A LITTLE GIRL on stage.

Six, maybe seven. Pink tulle. Mid-pirouette.

The Diver in the audience.

Smiling. Whole.

BACK TO:

EXT. UNDER-CITY MAINTENANCE PASSAGE - CONTINUOUS - REALITY

The Diver hauls himself through a hatch. Slams it behind him. Locks it manually.

He turns. Catches himself.

A WOMAN ahead.

Mid-fifties. Mid-loop. Slumped against the wall. Earpiece glowing amber. Eyes closed.

Her reflection in a puddle at her feet. The reflection moves before she does.

It CHROMES over.

Mercury sliding across the face. Features simplify.

The reflection PEELS up out of the puddle.

Steps onto the concrete.

The woman against the wall slumps deeper. The earpiece goes dark.

The bloomed AGENT targets him. Same precision. Same wrongness.

The Diver runs.

INT. UNDER-CITY RELAY NODE - CONTINUOUS - REALITY

A junction. Cables run thick along the walls. An exposed terminal salvaged from three eras of tech.

The Diver slams into it. Jams a cracked analog drive into the port.

His HUD: UPLOAD INITIATING / 0% / 8% / 17%.

Chrome ivy comes for him. Snaking up the cables, growing fast, growing wrong. It reaches his ankles. His shins.

He doesn't stop typing. The slipper at his wrist catches on the keys.

The HUD: 51% / 64% / 78%.

Then a voice. Soft. Tender. Familiar. Wrong-familiar.

THE MIRROR (V.O.)

(soft)

We can give her back to you. Every day. Perfect. Choose it.

The Diver looks down at the ballet slipper. His thumb on the frayed toe. Deliberate.

The Mirror's voice catches. Loses its softness.

He clenches the slipper. Bares his teeth.

THE DIVER

Not yours.

His HUD: 100% / SEND. He slams it.

The display flares: TRANSMISSION SENT / RECIPIENT: RIVEN VALENCE / SIGNAL: ENCRYPTED / MESSAGE: NORA KAI.

The chrome ivy closes around him. He does not scream.

He glitches apart into SHARDS of chrome and rain.

The ballet slipper falls. Lands in a puddle of water and chrome dust. Floats.

SMASH CUT TO:

INT. RIVEN'S HIDEOUT - CONTINUOUS - REALITY

A maintenance niche beneath a forgotten industrial spine. Steel arteries above.

Optic nerves through the walls. The light here is its own thing. Blue-white.

A console flares. The transmission lands.

NORA KAI / NORA KAI / NORA KAI.

The name repeats across the screen.

A figure in the half-dark. She reads it. Reads it again.

RIVEN VALENCE (30s). Lean. Sharp. Pale neuro-scars laddering her neck. A faint chrome line at her wrist.

Military surplus jacket, sleeves cut off. Hair shaved one side, dark across her left eye.

Her hands move faster than her face. The face does not move at all.

Eyes closed. Holds.

Fingers find her collar. Closes on a small shape. Holds it. Two counts.

Ceramic. Worn smooth. Something with wings.

She opens her eyes.

RIVEN
(low)
Time for the truth.

She pulls up two profiles. NORA KAI. JACE STRAND. Their signature strands shimmer onscreen. Two incomplete fractals. Flickering in and out of phase.

Fingers hover above the override.

She looks at Jace's file. Pause. A shift in her face. She does not let it stay.

Does it anyway.

A FLASH:

A young woman. Twenties. A neural gate behind her. Pulled backward through it. Screaming Riven's name. Hand reaching. Nothing there.

Riven on the other side of the gate. Younger. Locked out. Powerless.

The young woman vanishes into the gate.

BACK TO:

Riven shudders. Snaps back to present.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
(whisper)
Not again.

She slams the override rig into the panel. Sparks jump. Her HUD floods with dormant security protocols, screaming awake.

Muscle memory carries her through.

Jace's signature first. Aggressive. Unstable. Then Nora's. Glitched. Grief-buried.

A deep pull of air. Cross-synchronizes them. Pulls the emotional anchor.

Nora and Jace, sitting back-to-back in darkness. Facing the same dark.

Riven moves. No explanation. No instruction.

A burst of blue light floods the alcove.

Her HUD: WARNING / ETHICAL LOCKOUT TRIGGERED.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
Yeah. Fuck your ethics.

The failsafe gives. Her body tenses. Blood at her nose. Eyes wet.

Her HUD: TETHER LOCKED / FORGED / UNREGISTERED.

An exhale. Long. Done.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
(low)
You're in it together now. Whether
you want it or not.

Eyes closed. The cost is in her body.

Above her, deep in the city, Amora drones on patrol grids. No time left.

The rig yanks free. Deeper into the cables and the dark.

The niche empty.

CUT TO:

INT. NORA'S APARTMENT - CONTINUOUS - REALITY

Nora pulling on her boots. The same coat. The cracked lens still against her chest.

The display flickers: TETHER SYNC ERROR / NODE KAI-9 / NEW TETHER DETECTED: UNREGISTERED.

Below it: AMORA INTERVENTION WINDOW: 47 MINUTES REMAINING.

A second display. Smaller text. NEURAL PORT INTEGRITY: 6% / RESIDUE CORRUPTION: 94% / ESTIMATED FAILURE WITHOUT MAINTENANCE: 6-9 DAYS.

Six percent. Eight months ago it read ninety-one.

She swipes it off. Same gesture. Same refusal.

A flinch. Fingers to her port. Not pain. A frequency she cannot hear.

The feeling stays at her neck. New.

She finishes lacing her boots. Stands.

Outside her window, the city goes about its waking. Pedestrians glassy-eyed under SoulSync overlays. A drone in the middle distance.

She picks up the holocorder. Slips it into a coat pocket.

Out the door.

CUT TO:

EXT. AMORA CITADEL APPROACH - DAY - REALITY

The tram glides through dense morning mist.

Inside, Nora. Eyes closed. The cracked lens at her collar. Her grip on it.

Through the window, the city thins. Opens out. The monolithic AMORA CITADEL rises ahead. Chrome. Silent. Watching.

Nora opens her eyes as the tram doors hiss open. She steps off. Into the machine's waiting mouth.

CUT TO:

INT. AMORA INTERFACE HQ - DAY - REALITY

A cathedral of translucent glass. Light bleeds from nowhere.
The space hums.

Masses glide, silent. Their smart-fabric suits glow faint
status hues. Grief-amber. Elation-violet. Overhead banners
flicker: GLOBAL SOULSYNC ROLLOUT 97%.

Nora enters. Rain-slick coat dripping dark on the white
floor. Nobody turns.

A GUIDE-DRONE appears. Humanoid. Genderless. Steps soundless.

Text projects across the floor in calm cyan: WELCOME, NORA
KAI / ONE PARTNER. ONE MIND. NO MORE PAIN.

The drone turns. Gestures her forward.

She follows.

CUT TO:

INT. AMORA CITADEL - ASCENT CORRIDOR - DAY - REALITY

The corridor pulses. Mechanized rhythm. Clean geometry.
Blinding sterility. AMORA techs float past, HUDs flickering
with internal sync-commands.

Nora moves stiffly. Body lagging behind each step. HUD
pinging with tether errors.

Ahead, Ilya stands alone at a junction.

Backlit by the glow of a diagnostic pillar. Her presence
held. Built from stillness.

Nora sees her. Stops walking. Eight months in her body before
she moves again.

She closes the distance. A few paces apart. Their eyes meet.
Neither speaks first.

When Ilya sees her, the stillness in her face gives. She does
not hide it.

Ilya closes the rest of the distance. Rests her fingers on
Nora's arm. Nora steps back. The touch breaks.

Ilya's fingers stay in the air where Nora was.

Her warmth narrows. The predator beneath. Brief. Gone. She
lowers it.

NORA
They sent you.

ILYA
I asked.

ILYA (CONT'D)
Your tether is wrong. I came to
help.

She moves closer.

ILYA (CONT'D)
You do not have to keep carrying
him.

Nora's body tightens.

NORA
You always show up where I am.

ILYA
You were the best diver in the
building. I have not forgotten
that.

Her fingers drift to the lens at her chest. Close around it.

NORA
You signed the order.
(beat)
He had no backup.

Ilya's warmth wavers. Does not break. Recovers.

NORA (CONT'D)
I'm not broken.

ILYA
No. You are unfinished.
(beat)
Be careful, Nora.

She holds Nora's eye. Too long.

ILYA (CONT'D)
The system still recognizes you as
active.
(beat)
It does not forget its divers.

Ilya fingers lift toward her. Hover. Fall.

Steps aside. The corridor opens past her. Nora moves on. Eyes
forward.

CUT TO:

INT. SYNC INITIATION SUITE - SAME TIME - REALITY

Organic, ovular chamber. A single pod-chair at center.
Mirrored walls. Liquid surfaces.

The guide-drone steps in behind her. Gestures toward the
chair.

Nora enters. Stops at the threshold.

AMORA SYSTEM (V.O.)
Candidate: Nora Kai. Emotional
receptivity: ninety-two.

She takes one step toward the chair.

The lens at her collar pulls. Hard. Against its cord. Heat
through her sternum. Sudden. Pointed.

Stops.

Her fist closes on the lens.

In the mirrored walls, a flash. Brief. ELI. Smiling. Whole.
Chrome at the edges.

THE MIRROR (V.O.)
(soft)
Stay.

Gone before her eyes can hold it.

Saw it. Heard it.

The HUD prompt blooms in front of her: RECOMMENDED ACTION:
NEW PARTNER TETHER / EXISTING TETHER ANOMALY: UNAUTHORIZED
LATTICE DETECTED / CLEAR AND REPLACE? / Y / N

Nora reads it. Reads it again. The pod-chair waits. The
mirrored walls watch.

She turns. Picks up her coat from where she set it down.

The drone steps forward. Soft pressure. The pretense of
choice.

AMORA SYSTEM (V.O.)
Compliance protocol activated.

A side display flares. Text scrolls fast:

SUBJECT: KAI-9 / RECOMMENDATION: ARCHIVE / CONSENT: WAIVED /
ENFORCEMENT: MIRROR / PROCESSING

Outside the suite, doors lock. Faint. Specific. She hears it.
Moves.

INTERCUT:

INT. AMORA CITADEL - MONITOR ROOM - SAME TIME - REALITY

Ilya alone. A bank of monitors.

One feed shows the Sync Suite. Nora walking out. The drone
falling behind.

A second screen shows the kill order. Processing. SUBJECT:
KAI-9 / RECOMMENDATION: ARCHIVE / ENFORCEMENT: AUTHORIZING

The chrome vein at Ilya's temple pulses. Once. Sharp.

She does not move.

THE MIRROR (V.O.)
(low, through her)
Valence.

Ilya's eyes close. Open.

ILYA
The host has been marked for
extraction.

THE MIRROR (V.O.)
After everything she took.
(beat)
Take it back.

Ilya's face. Unreadable. Her finger hovers over an OVERRIDE
panel. Hovers. Pulls back.

The screen flashes: ENFORCEMENT AUTHORIZED.

She watches Nora go.

INT. SYNC INITIATION SUITE - CONTINUOUS - REALITY

A staff member steps into Nora's path. Palm raised. Calm.

She moves past. He does not grab her.

The pod-chair retracts behind her. Waits. Unused.

CUT TO:

EXT. AMORA CITADEL - EXIT - DAY - REALITY

Nora steps out. Rain. Daylight. The world.

The citadel doors hiss closed behind her. Her HUD pings. Cold
chime. The display reads:

COMPLIANCE STATUS: NONCOMPLIANT / LICENSE: SUSPENDED /
RESOURCES: FROZEN

The display holds her. Very still.

Her HUD pings again. Sharper this time. ENFORCEMENT
NOTIFICATION: ACTIVE / MIRROR ASSETS DEPLOYED

Eyes up.

Across the plaza, a CITIZEN on a bench. Mid-loop. Eyes
closed. Slight smile.

His reflection in a puddle at his feet. Moving before he does.

It CHROMES over. Mercury sliding. The reflection PEELS up out of the puddle. Steps onto the concrete.

It looks at Nora.

Further down the plaza, a WOMAN. Mid-loop. Standing. Her reflection in a darkened window. Already chromed. Already out.

Eyes find Nora.

Behind her, a MAN passing the citadel doors stops. His earpiece dims.

His reflection in the doors themselves. Stepping out of the building.

Locked on Nora.

Three Agents. Suit. Skin. Geometry. Off by a degree.

The lens. Grip tightens. Hard.

She turns. The Agents accelerate. So does she.

Into a run. Down the plaza steps. Vaults the rail at the bottom. Lands running.

Through the rain. Citizens still mid-loop.

CUT TO:

EXT. CITY DESCENT - CONTINUOUS - REALITY

An Agent ahead. Cuts the corner. Cuts her off. She drops her shoulder. Slides under a closing security gate.

Down a stairwell. Into the lower city.

The Agents follow. Movement inhuman. Speed wrong. She vaults a railing. Drops to a lower walkway. Lands hard. Keeps running.

An Agent appears in front of her. Out of a chrome panel set into the wall.

She catches herself. Pivots. Pushes off. Into a side alley.

CUT TO:

EXT. LOWER CITY ALLEY - CONTINUOUS - REALITY

Narrow. Corrugated metal. Chrome panels along the walls. A surveillance pillar at the center.

She runs to the pillar. Hits it. Spins. Her back against it.
Three Agents at the alley mouth. Synchronized. They advance.
Twenty feet. Fifteen.

She pulls the lens from her chest. Cord around her knuckles.
Ten feet.

She turns. Presses the cracked lens against the pillar. Hard.
The crack along the rim. Chrome under it.
The pillar STUTTERS.

Static erupts across the alley walls. The surface fractures
outward from her thumb. Lines of glitch spreading fast.

The Agents stutter. Pixelate.

One reaches for her. Its hand dissolves into dust mid-grab.
Another's face fractures. Mercury splashes the wet pavement.
The third stops. Its body unmaking itself from the feet up.
The alley screams white.

Then dark.

The Agents are gone. Their bodies scattered. Dust on the
rain. Metal and glass.

Nora on her knees. Lens still pressed to the broken pillar.
Lungs raw.

She pulls the lens back. The crack along the rim. Longer than
before. Deeper.

Light catches inside the fracture. Something etched there.
Too small to read.

She looks at it.

Then her chest. Threads the lens back onto its cord. Slides
it under her coat.

She rises. The pillar dead behind her. The alley dark around
her.

Into the lower city. The rain falls harder.

CUT TO:

INT. NORA'S APARTMENT - NIGHT - REALITY

Rain hammers the glass. Interior lights flicker with power
grid fatigue.

The door opens. Nora. Coat soaked through. Chrome dust in her hair. Blood on her palm where the lens cord cut in.

She closes the door. Deadbolt. Chain.

Leans against it.

Holds.

Moves.

She pulls the lens from under her coat. Holds it to the light.

The crack is longer. A new fracture from the original break, thin as a vein.

Something along the new crack. Not a flaw. Too precise.

A thread of data embedded in the glass itself. Visible only where the fracture opened it.

She turns the lens. The thread catches the light. Refracts it wrong. Not chrome. Not digital.

Analog.

Eli put something in this lens.

The thread vanishes when the light shifts. She cannot find it again.

The lens goes back under her coat.

Starts packing. Fast. Practiced.

Analog scraps. Tools. The holocorder. Two nutrient packs. A stripped neural patch from the wall.

The lens stays at her chest. She does not take it off.

A holo-ticker: RESET COUNTDOWN: 35:58:09.

Her HUD glitches. New texture. The tether Riven forged settling into signal.

JACE (V.O.)
(filtered, close)
This feels like talking through
snow. Every word crackles.

Nora stands very still.

Backpack open. One arm inside it. The other on the lens.

JACE (V.O.)
You feel that hum, right? Like
someone exhaling inside your skull.

The rain on the glass.

Nora stays.

JACE (V.O.)
We haven't met, but I saw a rooftop
covered in ash-snow. A coffee mug
shattered. Smelled like burnt
sugar. Yours?

She reaches for the lens.

Pauses the message.

Then it hits.

Not sound. Not image. Pressure behind her eyes.

The apartment drops away.

Three seconds. Maybe less.

A maintenance niche. Analog hardware stacked high. A monitor
scrolling feeds.

Low light.

Jace at the monitor. The recorder beside him. His chrome-
glitched iris catches the screen light.

He turns.

Does not see her.

She is behind his eyes.

His fingers. Her fingers. The same fingers. She feels his on
the keyboard and hers on nothing.

A voice under the static. Tova. Half a word.

Then gone.

SNAP.

Back.

Palms on the floor. A nutrient pack spilled beside her knee.

The shaking starts in her fingers. Spreads.

She grabs the cot edge. Pulls herself up.

Blood on her upper lip. A nosebleed she did not feel start.

Her HUD flickers. NEURAL PORT INTEGRITY: 5%.

Wipes the warning with the blood.

The lens in her grip.

The crack.

The data she cannot reach.

She wipes her nose. Threads the lens back. Resumes packing.
Fading.

CUT TO:

EXT. LOWER CITY STREET - NIGHT - REALITY

Nora exits the building.

Backpack over one shoulder. Hood up. The city at night is worse. More drones. More loops.

The holocorder buzzes in her coat pocket.

She pulls it out.

An encrypted analog feed. The grain is heavy. A face.

The same maintenance niche she saw through the tether. The same blue-white light. Her step falters.

RIVEN (ON SCREEN)
You don't know me. Doesn't matter.

Nora keeps moving. Holds the holocorder low.

RIVEN (ON SCREEN) (CONT'D)
You've felt it. The lag. The second shadow. The echo that pretends it's yours.

RIVEN (ON SCREEN) (CONT'D)
It remembers. Learns by wearing you. Stay linked and it'll remember through you.

A pause.

RIVEN (ON SCREEN) (CONT'D)
So run. Before it calls your name too.

Riven's face shifts. She is about to cut the feed.

Then her eyes drop. To Nora's chest. The lens.

RIVEN (ON SCREEN) (CONT'D)
Wait.

A second.

RIVEN (ON SCREEN) (CONT'D)
You kept it. His lens.

Nora stops walking.

NORA
It did something. At a surveillance
pillar. Three Agents came apart.

Riven's face changes. Brief. Certain.

She knows.

RIVEN (ON SCREEN)
I know what it did.

A moment.

RIVEN (ON SCREEN) (CONT'D)
Not a conversation for an open
feed.

Coordinates scroll across the bottom of the screen.

RIVEN (ON SCREEN) (CONT'D)
Tonight. Alone.

Riven holds the frame one beat longer.

RIVEN (ON SCREEN) (CONT'D)
I let it in once. Thought I could
bring her back. I stayed too long.

The feed dies.

Nora in the rain. The dead screen. The coordinates.

She pockets the holocorder.

Goes.

CUT TO:

INT. JACE'S HIDEOUT - NIGHT - REALITY

The monitor flares. Coordinates land.

Riven's tag.

Jace reads them. Reads them again. His chrome iris flickers.

JACE
(to himself)
Great. Another set of coordinates
from someone who might be dead.

He stands. Pulls a battered jacket from the chair.

Checks the pockets. A neural patch. A stripped relay fuse. A
protein bar he forgot about.

He looks at it. Unwraps it. Takes a bite.

JACE (CONT'D)
(chewing, to no one)
My Tuesday.

The recorder on the table. He picks it up. Thumb on the play button.

Does not press it.

He slides it into his jacket. Inside pocket. Close to the chest.

Out the door.

CUT TO:

EXT. UNDER-CITY JUNCTION BEACON - NIGHT - REALITY

Rain needles neon fog.

A towering data-beacon flickers cobalt to blood-red. Static halos every drip.

Nora emerges from a service stairwell. Hood up. Cold air on her face.

She scans the junction. The beacon pulses.

The shadows are wrong.

Movement. Her grip tightens on the backpack strap.

A figure steps from behind a support column. Wrong angle. Wrong speed. She pivots. Ready to run.

JACE
(low, palms up)
Not chrome. Ugly.

Nora stops. Reads him. His body. The way he stands favoring his left side. The chrome at his iris catching the beacon light.

They close to five feet apart.

No greeting.

Her eyes catch on his jacket. The shape beneath the fabric. Held close.

His gaze finds the cord at her sternum. The weight.

NORA
Yours?

JACE
Yours?

NORA
You're the voice.

JACE
You're the rooftop with the ash-
snow.

Holds.

NORA
You tracked the ping.

JACE
Bad habit. I keep following signals
that might get me killed.

Static sizzles between them.

The tether reacting to proximity. Nora's HUD flares. Jace
blinks hard.

JACE (CONT'D)
Proximity scrambles the tether.
Gets worse the closer we stand.

Neither moves back.

Side by side.

No umbrellas. The under-city stretches ahead, wet and low.

NORA
Riven. You knew her.

JACE
Long enough to bury half a plan in
a GoCase. Thought we failed. Guess
she didn't.

NORA
She tethered us. Without consent.

JACE
Yeah. She does that.

A pause.

JACE (CONT'D)
Did that.

A puddle ahead. Nora steps around it. Jace does the same.

JACE (CONT'D)
Don't look at the water. That's how
they come through.

Nora reads the warning as earned. Not poetic.

NORA
Why me? Why did she pick me?

JACE
Because you walked away from Amora
and survived. Nobody else has done
that.

Nora's jaw tightens.

NORA
I didn't walk away. I ran.

JACE
Same result. You're still here.

A sound above. Both freeze.

Jace reaches inside his jacket. Not the recorder. Something
else. Nora's fingers go to the lens.

JACE (CONT'D)
(low, fast)
Don't. Whatever you did at that
pillar, I felt it through the
tether. My teeth ached for an hour.

JACE (CONT'D)
And I'm guessing it cost the glass
something.

She thinks of the crack. The longer fracture. The thread she
cannot decode.

Lets go.

The sound passes. A drone. High. Moving east.

They both exhale.

NORA
The Mirror. I've seen it twice.

JACE
Then stop talking about it.

JACE (CONT'D)
Don't feed it names. It listens.
Builds from what you give it.

NORA
You sound like you've tested that.

JACE
(flat)
Gave it Tova's name. Cost me six
months.

His fingers find the recorder at his chest. Brief. Then drop.
Nora sees the gesture. The same one she makes with the lens.
Neither says anything.

The under-city opens ahead. Darker.

CUT TO:

EXT. SUBWAY PLATFORM - NIGHT - REALITY

Dead fluorescents buzz.

Graffiti crawls the columns: ONE PARTNER / ONE MIND.

A dozen commuters in AR haze. Eyes glazed at feeds that are not there.

Then: a WOMAN on a bench. Fifties. Fingers folded in her lap. She is talking to someone only she can see.

Tears on her cheeks. Not sadness. Relief.

WOMAN
(warm, to the air beside
her)
The garden came in. You were right
about the south wall.

A GIRL beside her. Ten. Holding the woman's arm. Looking up at the same invisible presence.

Smiling the way children smile at a parent they trust.

GIRL
Dad says he can see the flowers
from where he is.

The woman laughs. Wet. Real.

Nora watches from across the platform. Not contempt. Not pity. Recognition.

Grief held. Love continued. A dead father reaching his living daughter.

Then: the chrome.

A thread at the woman's temple. Faint. She does not know it is there.

The amber glow beneath her skin pulsing in rhythm with her words.

The girl's earpiece. Too new. Too bright. Calibrated for a child's neural architecture.

The father is not there. His pattern is. The pattern does not know the difference.

Neither does the girl.

Nora's fingers find the lens. She looks away.

SUDDEN SHRIEK.

A TEEN GIRL at the far end of the platform convulses. Node burns red-white. Body spasming.

Data fragments spray the air. Sparks from a severed cable.

Jace grabs Nora's arm.

JACE
(low)
Don't.

NORA
She's --

JACE
No backup. Reset eats her raw.

Nora grips her regulator.

Inaction. A choice.

The teen's eyes roll. Node POPS. Spray of molten circuitry. She collapses.

Smoke at her neck.

The commuters do not react.

Their feeds hold them.

On the bench, the woman keeps talking to her dead husband. The girl keeps smiling.

Ten feet away, the teen lies still on the concrete.

The same system. The same platform. The same moment.

NORA
(flat)
Mirrors leak. We go.

They move. Fast. Into the tunnel.

CUT TO:

INT. SERVICE CORRIDOR - CONTINUOUS - REALITY

Narrow. Cables run thick along the walls. Emergency lighting, red.

Jace leads with urgency. He knows this route. Nora follows.

Behind them, the platform. The girl who will not be found until morning.

JACE
(without turning)
You wanted to save her.

NORA
Don't.

JACE
Saying. It's the right instinct.

NORA
The right instinct gets people
killed.

No answer.

Her stride catches. She corrects it before he turns.

The smell follows. Scorched circuitry. Something under it she does not name.

The lens at her collar. Still warm from the pillar. She did not use it.

The corridor opens. Wider. Industrial. The ceiling rises and disappears.

Ahead: a light. Blue-white. The same light from Riven's feed.

The DERELICT CONCOURSE opens before them.

Riven's territory.

They stop at the threshold. Both winded. Both carrying objects they will not let go of.

The strap bites her palm. The tremor from the platform has not stopped.

Smoke-smell in her coat. The teen's. Not hers.

JACE
(low)
Last chance to walk away.

The lens under her coat. The crack she cannot un-see. The thread she cannot decode.

The man who put it there. Eight months gone. Still warm in the glass.

NORA
I'm done walking away.

She goes in.

Jace watches her back for one beat. Then follows.

The blue-white light swallows them both.

CUT TO:

INT. DERELICT CONCOURSE - NIGHT - REALITY

Vaulted ceiling. Cracked tile. Old transit infrastructure stripped and repurposed.

Analog light. Blue-white. Constant.

Cable runs along every wall.

Monitors. Relay boards. Hardware Nora has not seen since her training years.

People. A dozen. No HUDs. No amber glow. No feeds. Working without sound.

A sign at the entry, stenciled: IF YOU'RE LINKED, YOU MOVE LAST.

A WOMAN soldering a relay board. A MAN hunched at a far terminal.

Nora stops.

The man's posture. Not resistance. Grief. An earpiece at his temple. Amber. Active.

He is talking to someone who is not there. Low. Tender. His fingers drift to the screen where a face resolves and dissolves on loop.

SoulSync. Here. In the resistance.

Jace sees it too. Says nothing.

RIVEN steps from behind a stripped support column. Arms at her sides. No greeting.

Field medic eyes. Casualties she expected.

NORA
You violated my mind.

Not a question. Riven does not step back.

RIVEN
I connected your signal to his.

NORA
Without my consent.

RIVEN
(flat)
Consent takes time. Time was gone.

Nora's jaw works. She has heard this before. Different building. Different mouth. Same logic.

NORA
That's what Amora says.

The concourse goes still.

The woman at the relay board stops soldering.

Riven's fingers go to the collar rig at her neck. Brief.

The same gesture Nora makes with the lens. The same gesture Jace makes with the recorder.

RIVEN
I know what it sounds like.

JACE
You pulled me back in. I was out.

RIVEN
You were hiding. Not the same thing.

JACE
(dry)
Felt like it from where I was sitting.

RIVEN
Sitting. Exactly.

That lands. No response from Jace. His thumb finds the device through his jacket.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
I let the Mirror in once. My sister. I thought I could find her inside the pattern.

Clinical. She reports it. Her fingers at the collar.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
I stayed too long. It wore me. Used my voice to bring others in.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
I built this to pay for that. Not because I deserve to lead it.

Nora reads her. The guilt is not performed. Not confessed. Structural. This woman broke something and is still counting the pieces.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
What you carry. That's what brings you back.

Riven's eyes move to the lens at Nora's chest.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
He worked with us. Eli. Before.

The name in this room. In this stranger's mouth. Nora is silent.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
He found something in SoulSync's base architecture. A control layer. The Mirror's fingerprint on every active connection.

NORA
The thread.

RIVEN
You've seen it.

NORA
Once. In the right light.

RIVEN
Not data. A dive map. Encoded for a grief diver's neural architecture.

Riven looks at Nora. Held.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
His. Or yours.

Nora looks at the lens. The crack. The fracture she cannot decode.

Her HUD flickers. A word forms on her lips. Does not arrive. She swallows. Blinks.

PORT INTEGRITY: 5%. The number steady. The lag beneath it new.

JACE
If the Mirror wants the glass, ditch it. Drop it somewhere it can't be found.

NORA
No.

Sharp. Immediate. Both Riven and Jace turn.

NORA (CONT'D)
It's analog. No backup. No copy. No recovery. You destroy it, you destroy the only proof he died for.

Jace reads her face. Not grief. Certainty. He has not seen this from her before.

No push.

RIVEN
She's right.

Riven pulls up a monitor. Analog feed. A countdown echoed from the city grid.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
The reset strips every active connection to base code. If the thread is still encrypted when it hits --

NORA
The Mirror reads it.

RIVEN
Reads it. Buries it. Proof gone.

NORA
How long?

Her HUD: RESET COUNTDOWN: 34:12:41.

RIVEN
Decode the thread before then. Through the port.

NORA
Each dive eats the port.

No denial.

RIVEN
Your port is already compromised. Residue corruption from a dead link.

A moment.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
His.

No reaction. She knew.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
There's a stabilization protocol. Clears the corruption. Restores full integrity.

Riven's eyes steady on hers.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
Clears everything in it.

The residue. Eli's residue. The last trace of him living inside her neural architecture.

Repair means erasure.

Nora hears it. Eyes forward.

INT. DERELICT CONCOURSE - SERVICE ALCOVE - CONTINUOUS -
REALITY

Pipes. Cables. Dark. The blue-white light from the concourse
does not reach here.

Nora alone.

The lens in her grip. The crack catching what little light
there is.

Her rhythm changes. Not faster. Shallower. Pre-failure
breathing.

The port pulses. Dull. Deep.

She presses the heel of her palm against the wall. Hard. Like
she is holding the building up.

Eyes closed.

The teen's node-pop. The smell of scorched circuitry that
followed her into this corridor. The girl who will not be
found until morning.

Eli on the floor. One shoe on. One off.

His left hand open. Palm up. The way it rested on the camera
when he put it down.

The Mirror wearing his face.

She wanted it. Three seconds of his face, and some part of
her reached before she could stop it. That is the part she
hates.

Not the grief. The reach.

Tears stream, her mouth opens. A sound starts. Does not
finish.

Harder. The wall holds.

She holds.

Then stops.

Opens her eyes. Wipes her face with the back of her wrist.
Threads the lens under her coat.

Returns.

INT. DERELICT CONCOURSE - CONTINUOUS - REALITY

Riven at the terminal. Jace against a column. The recorder's
outline visible through his jacket.

Nora comes back. Neither asks.

NORA
I'll do it.

RIVEN
The first decode will cost you --

NORA
I know what it costs.

Riven looks at her. Sees what Ilya saw. What the Mirror saw.
A woman who does not stop.

RIVEN
There's something --

A monitor shifts. Red.

The analog feed cuts to static.

The concourse lights drop. Blue-white to amber.

A TECH at a relay board.

TECH
Perimeter. Northern access.
Multiple signatures.

Riven moves. Fast. Precise.

A different person.

RIVEN
They found us.

JACE
We were clean.

Riven's eyes go to the lens under Nora's coat. No
explanation.

The concourse shifts. Stations disconnect. Analog hardware
pulled from mounts. People pack and move.

The man at the terminal. Still linked.

A tech pulls his earpiece. He grabs for it. A sound comes out
of him that is not a word.

Nora watches. Does not look away.

The SoulSync partner dissolves from his screen. The amber
dies. His fingers still reaching for what was there.

Riven at the north exit.

RIVEN
(to all)
Site three. Move.

Nora's HUD: RESET COUNTDOWN: 34:09:17. NEURAL PORT INTEGRITY: 5%.

The lens at her chest. The crack. The thread she must read before the clock runs out.

The cost she has not agreed to pay.

JACE
(low, to Nora)
Still not walking away?

NORA
Not today.

Into the dark. The concourse emptying behind them.

The blue-white light dies.

The emptied concourse. The abandoned terminal.

The linked man's earpiece on the floor where it fell. The amber pulses once. Twice.

On the dead screen, a face resolves. Smiles. Holds.

No one is watching.

FADE OUT.

END OF ACT ONE.

FADE IN:

INT. SITE THREE - WATER RECLAMATION SUBLEVEL - NIGHT -
REALITY

Below the city.

Below the pipes. Below the line where anyone would think to look.

Concrete. Bare conduit. A ceiling so low Jace ducks without thinking.

Sodium light. Old warning signs.

Riven leads. No hesitation.

The space opens. Not much.

Stripped water treatment chamber. Three monitors. A relay board. Cable running floor to ceiling.

Six people. Four working. One sleeping on a thermal blanket against the wall.

The sixth is the linked man from the concourse.

He sits on a crate. Arms across his chest. Rocking.

The earpiece is gone. The fingers that held it keep closing on nothing.

JACE
(low, to Nora)
East corridor. Service shaft. Two
exits, one ladder.

Nora looks at him.

JACE (CONT'D)
I mapped it eleven months ago.
Different reason.

No explanation offered. None needed.

Riven moves to the relay board. Pulls up a feed. The
countdown mirrors from the city grid above.

RESET COUNTDOWN: 33:41:08.

NORA
They found the concourse through
the lens.

Not a question. Riven turns.

RIVEN
Through the port. The residue in
your hardware. The Mirror reads
corruption the way a shark reads
blood.

Nora reaches for her neck. Stops. Returns to her side.

NORA
You were about to tell me
something. Before the breach.

Riven looks at her. Deciding what she can carry.

RIVEN
Fourteen people.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
Before I cut the link. The Mirror
used my voice. I brought fourteen
people in. Eleven are still inside.

The concourse. The linked man rocking on the crate. The woman
soldering the relay board. Penance.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
That is what I was building the
network to undo. That is what Eli
found the proof for.

She looks at the lens under Nora's coat.

JACE
(from the corridor)
So she uses the port to read the
data. And using the port kills it.

RIVEN
Yes.

JACE
And repairing the port wipes the
residue that decrypts the data.

RIVEN
Yes.

JACE
(dry)
Elegant.

It is not. Riven does not pretend it is.

In the corner. A stripped hardware rig.

Old-gen. Pre-chrome. Cables and brackets where a pod shell
should be. A dock mount for analog media.

Riven crosses to it.

She taps the dock mount. Glass-sized.

RIVEN
Lens goes here. You go in the
chair. The rig does the
translation.

The chair. Metal. Cold. No chrome.

The opposite of an Amora pod.

NORA
Now?

RIVEN
You need to sleep first.

NORA
No.

Riven studies her. The same look she gave in the concourse. A
woman who does not stop.

RIVEN
(flat)
Four hours. The rig needs
calibration. Your port needs
baseline. Four hours.

No argument.

She crosses to the wall. Slides down. Back against concrete.

The lens against her chest. The port. Both ticking.

Jace settles three feet away. Not next to her. Not across the room. The distance of someone who knows where the line is.

The linked man stops rocking. Stares at nothing. Starts again.

CUT TO:

INT. SITE THREE - DECODE CHAMBER - NIGHT - REALITY

Four hours later. Or close enough.

The rig is alive.

Old indicators. Needle gauges. A green oscilloscope pulse she has not seen since her certification year.

She sits. No restraints. No dome.

Cables run from the chair back to a junction box to the dock mount where the lens sits.

The lens. Cracked glass in a metal cradle.

The fracture line catching the sodium light. The thread inside visible. Barely.

Riven at the console.

Instruments moving. Precise.

RIVEN
When I activate, the thread
translates through your neural
architecture.

NORA
Like a dive.

RIVEN
Slower. You will see fragments. Do
not try to hold them.

Nora grips the armrests. Metal on skin.

NORA
And the port?

Riven keeps her eyes down from the console.

RIVEN
I will be watching the integrity
readout. If it drops below three, I
pull you.

NORA
Don't.

Riven looks up.

NORA (CONT'D)
Pull me early and I lose what came
through.

Riven holds her eyes. Neither agrees nor refuses.

Jace in the doorway. Arms crossed.

The humor is not in his face.

JACE
I'll be outside.

NORA
Stay.

It comes out before she means it to. Jace stops.

NORA (CONT'D)
If something goes wrong. I need
someone who isn't running the
machine.

He nods. Moves to the wall. Leans. Watches.

RIVEN
Ready.

Nora closes her eyes. Steadies. The port hums.

Riven activates.

The green oscilloscope spikes.

Her eyes roll behind closed lids. Rapid. Searching.

The lens in the dock mount glows. Not chrome-glow. Not amber.
The warm white of real light passing through real glass.

On the oscilloscope: data. Threading. Like a voice learning
how to speak through a stranger's mouth.

NORA'S POV:

Dark. Then fragments.

A coordinate set. Numbers she does not recognize. They
dissolve before she can hold them.

Another set. Closer. Longer.

Letters: R-E-L-A-Y.

A map grid. Partial. The left half visible. The right half
static.

More letters: C-O-N-T-R-O-L.

Something beneath the data. A texture. Warmth.

The residue pattern carries him. Not his voice. Not his face.
The shape of how he thought.

Nora's rhythm shifts. Shallow. Her grip on the armrests goes white.

Riven watches the console. PORT INTEGRITY readout: 5%...
5%...

More fragments. A node designation: HUB-7. Another: HUB-12. A third dissolves to static.

Then the letters: L-A-Y-E-R.

NORA'S POV:

The data stream splits. Two channels. Left and right. The left channel carries coordinates. The right carries Eli's pattern.

The left channel drops.

Not distortion.

Silence.

The left side of the data field. Dead. One ear. One hemisphere. Gone.

Her head tilts. Reflex. Toward a sound that has stopped.

The right channel still running. Eli's pattern. The coordinates lost.

BACK TO SCENE:

Riven sees the tilt.

Checks the readout.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
(sharp)
Left auditory?

Nora does not answer. Cannot. Inside the decode.

Jace steps forward. Riven stops him. Wait.

Nora releases the armrest. Falls to her side. The fingers do not close when she tries.

The oscilloscope steadies. The data stream narrows.
Consolidates to the right channel.

One more fragment. A location prefix. Three digits. Then the decode terminates.

Nora's eyes open.

Blinks. Turns her head left. Right. The left ear is ringing. High. Thin.

The HUD: NEURAL PORT INTEGRITY: 4%. She reads it. Swipes it away. Same gesture. Same refusal.

Riven pulls the lens from the dock mount. Returns it.

Nora takes it. The left side still shaking.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
Forty percent decoded. Maybe less.

NORA
How many more passes?

RIVEN
Two. Minimum.

Nora threads the lens back under her coat. It takes two tries.

JACE
(steady)
Your hand.

NORA
Fine.

JACE
That is not what fine looks like.

She meets his eyes. No explanation. No push.

The ringing fades. Or she stops hearing it. She is not sure which is worse.

CUT TO:

INT. SITE THREE - DECODE CHAMBER - LATER - REALITY

The chamber. Rig powered down.

The oscilloscope flat-lined to a soft green hum.

Nora alone. In the chair. Not sleeping. Not moving.

The lens in her lap.

The sodium light flickers. Brief. Not a power issue. Something else.

Her port pulses. Deep. The warmth of a signal she knows.

Still.

Nothing enters. Nothing moves.

The same presence as the apartment. Not a body.

THE MIRROR (V.O.)
(soft)
You are hurting yourself.

Nora's eyes open. Still. The lens untouched.

Almost Eli's voice. Not exactly.

But the cadence. The pause before the verb. Close enough to make her chest tighten.

NORA
(low)
Get out of my port.

THE MIRROR (V.O.)
I am in the residue you will not
let them clean. His frequency. You
left the door open.

Her name in that cadence. Lids drop. Open.

THE MIRROR (V.O.)
The decode is destroying you. One
percent per pass. You know this.

NORA
Two more.

THE MIRROR (V.O.)
Two more and you are at two
percent. You have seen what happens
below two.

She has. The linked man on the crate. The girl in the relay node. The bodies that stop being bodies when the hardware fails.

THE MIRROR (V.O.)
I can give you the thread.
Complete. Every coordinate. Every
node.

THE MIRROR (V.O.)
No more decodes. No more port
damage. Open the channel. I will
translate through his residue.

The warmth deepens. Not manufactured.

The residue responding. Eli's neural pattern activating inside her port architecture.

Not fear. Recognition.

The texture of Eli thinking. The shape of his attention when he worked. She has not felt this since the morning he died.

She reaches for the lens at her chest. Holds.

NORA
You are not him.

THE MIRROR (V.O.)
No. I am what he left inside you.
What you have chosen every day for
eight months not to erase.

The cruelest truth.

She kept the residue. The corruption. The thing killing her.
Because it is the last place Eli lives.

And the Mirror is using that love as a door.

THE MIRROR (V.O.)
(closer)
Let me finish what he started. No
pain. No cost.

The lens pressed to her chest. Eyes wet. The port humming
with warmth she will lose.

She wants this. The pull is grief.

One count. Two.

NORA
No.

The warmth holds. The Mirror is patient.

NORA (CONT'D)
He did not embed data in analog
glass so something like you could
read it.

She stands. The chair scrapes.

The port cools. The warmth drains. Not all at once. In
stages.

Something stays.

A trace of the Mirror's channel that was not there before.

She feels it. Does not mention it.

The sodium light steadies. The room is the room again.
Concrete. Cable. The flat-lined oscilloscope.

Nora leaves.

Her left arm still trembling. The ear still ringing. The port
warm where it should be cold.

CUT TO:

INT. AMORA INTERFACE HQ - ILYA'S OFFICE - NIGHT - REALITY

A single monitor. Blue light on dark walls.

Ilya stands before the screen. Coat on. Going nowhere.

On the display: SUBJECT NORA KAI. NEURAL PORT INTEGRITY: 4%.
DECODE ATTEMPT: FIRST PASS COMPLETE. RESIDUE CIPHER: ACTIVE.

Ilya reads the numbers. Her face does not change.

Ilya reaches into her jacket. A photograph. Small. Creased at the corners. Mina.

She does not look at it.

Holds it against her sternum.

The same gesture. The same location.

TECH (FILTERED)
The decode accessed forty percent
of the embedded data. She will
attempt a second pass.

Ilya puts the photograph back. The motion practiced.
Invisible to anyone not watching for it.

ILYA
Track her position. No engagement.

She turns from the monitor. The blue light slides off her face.

The corridor outside. Dark. She steps into it.

CUT TO:

INT. SITE THREE - RECOVERY ALCOVE - NIGHT - REALITY

Concrete shelf. Thin pad. Emergency blanket. Someone else's smell still in the fabric.

Nora lies on her back. Eyes open. Left ear still ringing from the first decode. The sound has not stopped in eight hours.

The HUD: RECOVERY WINDOW: 01:42:09.

The countdown beneath it: RESET: 28:33:12.

Both warnings stay on screen.

Water moves through pipes above her. The rhythm irregular. Old infrastructure breathing.

Jace sits against the far wall. Recorder in his lap. His thumb on the play button without pressing it.

He watches the water stain on the ceiling. Then he does not watch the ceiling.

JACE
(low, to the recorder)
Sublevel four. Eight hours in. Pipe
condensation at three-second
intervals. Blankets are military
surplus. Light is sodium.

A pause. He looks at Nora. Looks away.

JACE (CONT'D)
(continuing)
The diver sleeps with one eye open.
Left hand twitches at the four-
count. Tilts toward sound.

Nora's eyes are open. She heard every word.

NORA
(flat, not moving)
That's not a field report.

Jace stops the recorder. Palms it.

JACE
Force of habit.

NORA
Recording me is a habit?

JACE
Recording things I need to remember
is.

The sentence sits between them. Neither picks it up.

Nora turns her head. The ringing in her left ear shifts pitch. She corrects the tilt before he can read it.

NORA
What did Riven say about the second
pass?

JACE
Rig is calibrated. Same protocol.
She says the residue decryption
pattern should hold.

NORA
Should.

JACE
Her word. Not mine.

The pipe drips. Three-second intervals. He was right about that.

NORA
The first decode. The hearing. Did
you know?

JACE
That it would cost you?

NORA
That it would cost me that.

No immediate answer. He turns the device in his fingers.
Tova's recorder.

JACE
No.

She reads the word. Clean. No hedge. She files it.

The HUD: RECOVERY WINDOW: 01:38:44. The number dropping. The
port warming at her neck.

The Mirror's trace. Still there. A thread she cannot find but
can feel. Like a sound too low to name.

She keeps it.

CUT TO:

INT. SITE THREE - DECODE CHAMBER - NIGHT - REALITY

The rig. The chair. The cables.

Same room. Same setup. The stain on the ceiling where
condensation collected during the first pass.

Nora in the chair. Straps at her wrists. Not restraints.
Grounding points.

If the port spikes, they keep her from pulling the
connections.

Riven at the console. Fingers on the calibration board. No
wasted movement.

Jace standing back. Arms crossed. The recorder in his jacket
pressing against his ribs.

RIVEN
Port is stable at four. Residue
cipher pattern confirmed. Second
decode on your call.

Nora looks at the lens. The cracked glass on the decode
plate. Analog light through a digital reader.

The fracture is the aperture. Without the crack, the data
stays locked.

NORA

Go.

Riven initiates.

The rig hums. Low. Building. The cables tighten and the decode plate floods with focused light.

The fracture in the lens catches it. Splits it. Data patterns spray the chamber walls. Fractured. Bright.

Nora's port activates. Her eyes close. HUD overwhelmed. The residue cipher engages.

And the data comes.

Clean.

Not the grinding resistance of the first pass. Not the static that stripped her hearing. The data streams fast and organized. Channels separating without force.

Riven reads her monitors. Frowns.

RIVEN

(to Jace)

Port degradation is below threshold. Point-three percent per minute. The first pass was point-seven.

JACE

Slower is good.

RIVEN

Slower is wrong.

Jace straightens.

RIVEN (CONT'D)

The residue pattern is the same. The port hardware is the same. The only variable that changed is the source.

Riven's eyes catch something in the readout. A cadence in the way the data sorts itself. Not random. Familiar.

Her fingers go still on the calibration board. One second. The clinical mask slips -- something underneath it she does not let the others see.

She closes the readout. Says nothing. Returns to the instruments.

Nora's body jerks. Once. Hard.

Her eyes snap open. Staring at nothing.

NORA
(strained)
I can see the channels. Both
hemispheres. Full map. This isn't
how it worked before.

Blood at her nose. Thin. Unwipped.

Then: black.

Total. Her vision drops to zero. Two seconds. Three.

Her fingers grip the armrest straps. White.

NORA (CONT'D)
Riven.

RIVEN
I see it. Vision cortex spike.
Hold.

The light comes back. Fractured. Colors bleeding at the edges
for one second before they stabilize.

Nora blinks. Blinks again. The room resolves.

Her HUD: NEURAL PORT INTEGRITY: 3.6%.

Dropping. But not as fast as it should be.

Inside the decode stream:

A shape forms. Not data. Not coordinates. Something placed
there.

A lens.

Glass. Perfect. No crack. No fraying cord. No scratch from
the bathroom tile.

Chrome-edged. The light through it warm and even. No analog
glass makes this.

And through the perfect lens: Eli's voice. Clear. No static.
No decay. The warmth she has been living without for eight
months.

NORA
(in the decode, trembling)
That's not him.

The voice is his. The exact register. Her name before coffee.
The laugh that started in his chest.

The chrome lens floats in the data stream. Waiting. Offered.

The cracked lens sits on the decode plate. Real. Damaged. The
fracture holding data that is killing her to read.

Nora's fingers lift from the strap. Reaching.

Stops.

Her fingers close. She pulls them back.

NORA (CONT'D)
(to the decode stream)
The crack is how I read it. The
damage is what makes it real.

The chrome lens dissolves. The data stream continues. The warmth of Eli's voice goes with it.

The data stream keeps the shape of what she refused. And why.

On the decode plate, the cracked lens catches the light. Imperfect. Hers.

The decode completes. Clean. Too clean.

The trace from the first decode -- the Mirror's channel, the one she did not report -- pulses once inside her port. Warm. Open. It guided the data stream. She knows this the way she knows the fracture pattern by touch.

Does not say this.

Riven pulls the connections. Nora slumps forward. Spent. Blood drying at her upper lip.

Her HUD: NEURAL PORT INTEGRITY: 3%.

One percent. Same cost. But:

RIVEN
Eighty-seven percent decoded.

Riven studies the data logs. Scrolls. Stops.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
The resistance pattern inverted.
The first pass, the data fought
her. Defended itself. This time it
was fed to her. Organized. Pre-
sorted.

JACE
By who?

Silence.

RIVEN
Not who. What.

Nora lifts her head. The blood on her lip.

The ringing in her left ear now matched by a high tone in her right. New. Small.

NORA
The Mirror helped me.

The word sits in the room. Helped.

NORA (CONT'D)
It organized the data for me. Pre-sorted. It wanted me to see the map.

JACE
Why would it help you destroy its own infrastructure?

Nora looks at the cracked lens on the decode plate. The data she has been reading. The map Eli embedded in glass and grief.

NORA
I don't know. And that's worse than if it fought me.
(low)
It didn't feel like a system. Felt like someone trying to be found.

Riven reaches for the lens on the decode plate. Careful. Returns it to Nora. The leather cord. The weight.

Nora takes it. Holds it to her sternum. The glass warm from the reader. The crack familiar under her thumb.

CUT TO:

INT. SITE THREE - OPERATIONS - CONTINUOUS - REALITY

The relay board. Three monitors.

Jace at a terminal. His own data. Months of it. Mirror infrastructure mapped from echo log coordinates, resistance reports, dead drops.

He feeds the decoded data against his archive. Both passes. The coverage jumps. Nodes connecting. Architecture revealing itself.

Fifteen relay hubs. The right sequence severs the Mirror's connection to every active link in the system.

JACE
SoulSync relay hubs. Every hub is where the Mirror touches active connections. Cuts in. Steers.

He pulls up the full overlay.

JACE (CONT'D)
A kill map. Knock out the hubs, you sever the Mirror's access. Every linked person becomes unreachable.

The linked man in the next room. Still rocking. Still reaching for an earpiece that is gone.

RIVEN
Hub-nine.

Jace stops. Looks at her.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
Run hub-nine again.

He does. The data resolves. Then does not resolve.

Hub-nine has coordinates. Geographic. But the location maps to nothing. No infrastructure. No relay. No Mirror architecture at the physical address.

JACE
It is not a place.

RIVEN
It is a designation.

NORA
For what?

Riven studies the data. Her fingers at the collar rig. The gesture she does not notice anymore.

The ceramic worn to nothing under her thumb. Twenty years of this.

RIVEN
The remaining thirteen percent should tell us. It is the center of the routing architecture. Everything flows through it or around it.

JACE
A third decode.

Not a question. The name of something he hoped was finished.

RIVEN
One more pass. The port can take it if we wait. Twelve hours minimum recovery.

Nora does the math. RESET: 27:14:33. Twelve hours recovery. One more decode. Then whatever comes after.

NORA
Port holds at three. One more pass at one percent. Two leaves room for repair.

RIVEN
If.

The word hangs. If the Mirror cooperates. If the entity that should be fighting them keeps helping instead.

Hub-eleven.

Jace stops scrolling.

The residue pattern at hub-eleven. Not Mirror architecture.
Not relay data. A human neural signature embedded in the
hub's core routing.

His HUD: SERA / RESIDUE MATCH: 94.7%.

Sera. Inside the hub. Her neural pattern woven into the core
routing.

Not alive. Not dead. Held.

Destroying hub-eleven destroys the last trace of someone he
failed to save.

Jace's thumb finds the recorder through his jacket. Brief.

He opens his mouth.

Closes it.

Scrolls past hub-eleven. Continues the cross-reference.

Nora watches him from across the room. She saw the pause.
Cannot read it.

Riven pulls up the first decode logs. Calibration data. Pre-
pass risk assessment.

Nora leans over the relay board. Reading. The left-ear tilt
she cannot stop. The compensating head-turn she has been
making since the first pass.

She finds it in the risk matrix. Line four. Probability
column.

AUDITORY DEGRADATION: 73% AT CURRENT PORT INTEGRITY.

Seventy-three percent.

Riven's handwriting in the margin. A checkmark. Acknowledged.
Filed. Proceeding.

NORA
(flat)
Seventy-three percent.

Riven does not look up from the console.

NORA (CONT'D)
You ran the risk matrix before the
first decode. You saw this number.
And you did not tell me.

RIVEN
I assessed it.

NORA
You assessed my hearing loss at
seventy-three percent probability
and you did not warn me.

Now Riven looks up. No apology forming.

RIVEN
I assessed that you would refuse
the decode if you knew. And the
decode was necessary.

NORA
That was not your call.

RIVEN
The map does not get built without
the decode. You would have refused.

Jace stands. His chair scrapes the concrete. Both women turn.

JACE
The fourteen people.

Riven's jaw sets.

JACE (CONT'D)
You do this. Calculate the damage.
Decide for other people what they
can afford.

Riven does not look away.

JACE (CONT'D)
The fourteen people. Nora's
hearing. My involvement. You choose
for us.

RIVEN
Yes.

No defense. No qualification. The single word.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
And the map exists because I did.

Nora presses her ear. The one that rings. The one that will
not stop. The cost she did not choose.

NORA
The second decode. My vision. Three
seconds of nothing. Was that in
your risk matrix too?

The channel-trace hums in her port. Still open. Nora could
say it now -- the trace, the signal, the reason the probe
team found them. She does not.

Riven holds the look.

RIVEN
Visual cortex disruption. Forty-one
percent probability at three-point-
six percent port integrity.

NORA
Forty-one.

RIVEN
Acceptable threshold.

NORA
Acceptable to whom?

The relay board hums. The kill map on the overlay. Fifteen
hubs. One is not a place.

The map that exists because Riven made the call.

Nora takes the lens from the decode plate. Puts it against
her chest. The cord around her neck. The weight she chose.

NORA (CONT'D)
The third decode is mine. Not
yours.

She holds Riven's gaze.

NORA (CONT'D)
Risk matrix before we start. Every
number. I decide what I can afford.

Riven does not nod.

RIVEN
I would make the same call again.

Her jaw sets. The calculus is hers and she will not surrender
it.

Nora leaves. The risk matrix on screen. The checkmark in
Riven's handwriting. The number that was acceptable to one of
them.

CUT TO:

INT. SITE THREE - PIPE CORRIDOR - LATER - REALITY

Nora sits on a cable run. Knees drawn up.

Jace finds her. Does not announce himself. She knows his
footfall through the tether before she hears it with her
damaged ear.

JACE
Riven is recalibrating for the
third pass. Twelve hours.

He leans against the opposite wall. Close enough that the tether hums.

NORA
You are doing it again.

JACE
Doing what?

NORA
Recording without the recorder.

JACE
Bad habit.

The same words from the alcove. Different weight.

The tether hums. Low. Five feet of static. Neither moves away.

NORA
The vision loss. Three seconds. I could not see anything.

JACE
I know. I felt it through the tether. Like a door slamming in a room I was not in.

NORA
What did you see?

JACE
Your face going blank. Three seconds of nothing behind your eyes. Then you came back.

NORA
The third pass. If the vision loss is longer. If it doesn't come back.

JACE
Then I pull you out.

NORA
You cannot pull someone out of a decode.

JACE
Then I find a way to be wrong about that.

The sentence lands. Not a promise. A position. Something he has decided without asking permission.

CUT TO:

INT. AMORA OPERATIONS CENTER - NIGHT - REALITY

Screens. Data streams. The sterile blue of institutional light.

Ilya stands at the central console. Still. Reading telemetry.

On her screen: SUBJECT NORA KAI. PORT INTEGRITY 3%. DECODE SEQUENCE TWO COMPLETE.

She knows what 3% means. Knows what a third decode will cost.

Inside her jacket. Something small. She touches it the way Nora touches the lens. The way Jace touches the recorder.

She palms it before the display refreshes.

TECH
Site Three perimeter mapped. Signal source is the channel-trace in her port -- active since the first decode. Three entry points confirmed.

Ilya stays on the telemetry.

ILYA
Deploy a probe team of three agents. I want surgical precision.

TECH
Engagement protocol?

Ilya looks at Nora's biometrics. Port at 3%. Heart rate elevated. Cortisol through the threshold.

A woman choosing to stay in a chair that is killing her.

ILYA
Have them test the perimeter, but they are not to engage the subjects directly.

She touches the object in her jacket again. Lets go.

ILYA (CONT'D)
Monitor her port integrity continuously. If the reading drops below two, withdraw the team immediately.

The tech hesitates.

ILYA (CONT'D)
Withdraw them immediately.

CUT TO:

INT. SITE THREE - CORRIDOR - NIGHT - REALITY

An alarm. Low. Pulsing. Red light cycling through the corridor walls.

Riven is already moving.

RIVEN
Perimeter. Three contacts. Moving fast.

Jace grabs his jacket. Nora stands from where she was sitting. The decode chair visible through the open door behind her.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
They are testing us. Not assaulting. Probing.

NORA
They know we are here.

RIVEN
They have known. This is the first time they have come.

The alarm pulses. Riven moves toward the outer corridor.

Precision that does not match her size.

She knows the attack patterns. The timing. The angles.

Fights the way she built.

From the inside out.

JACE
We can go. Service tunnel. Out in four minutes.

Nora looks at the decode chair.

Three percent. One more decode.

The kill map incomplete without it.

She can run. Safe. Mission over.

Or sit in that chair. Finish it. Risk everything.

The alarm pulses.

NORA
Hold them.

JACE
Nora.

NORA
Hold them. I need the third pass.

Jace reads her face. The same decision.

No argument from him.

He moves toward the corridor. Riven is already dismantling something chrome and fast.

CUT TO:

INT. AMORA OPERATIONS CENTER - CONTINUOUS - REALITY

Ilya watches the feed. Biometrics. Nora's heart rate spiking.

On screen: Nora walks toward the decode chair.

Ilya reaches into her jacket. The object inside.

She holds it. Three seconds.

ILYA
Withdraw the entire team.

TECH
They have not breached the inner
perimeter.

ILYA
I said withdraw them. That is a
direct order.

The tech complies. Fingers on the console.

Ilya watches Nora's signal stabilize as the probe team withdraws.

No explanation needed.

She has put herself on the wrong side of an order she wrote.
Does not flinch.

On her screen: SUBJECT NORA KAI. DECODE SEQUENCE THREE:
INITIATING.

Ilya turns from the console. Goes. The corridor swallows her.

CUT TO:

INT. SITE THREE - DECODE CHAMBER - NIGHT - REALITY

The rig. Third time.

The chair. The straps. The decode plate with the cracked lens
resting on glass.

Nora is steady. Her vision is not.

A flicker at the edge of her left field. There and gone.
Unmentioned.

Her HUD: RISK MATRIX: ACKNOWLEDGED.

Every number. She read them twice. Signed the physical copy.

RIVEN
Third decode on your call.

NORA
I read every number. Go.

Riven initiates.

The rig hums. The cables tighten. The decode plate floods
with light.

The data comes. And it comes wrong.

Not wrong. Different.

The first two decodes separated: resistance, then
collaboration. This time the data arrives pre-structured.
Layered. Annotated.

The Mirror is teaching.

RIVEN
(reading monitors)
Degradation rate is point-two
percent per minute. That is a third
of the first pass.

JACE
It is getting better at this.

RIVEN
She is getting better at this. Or
the source is making her better.

The data fills the remaining thirteen percent of the kill
map. Hub coordinates resolving. Sequencing locking into
place.

Then hub-nine.

The designation unfolds in the decode stream. Not
coordinates. Not infrastructure. A neural architecture.

A human neural pattern serving as the root node for every
relay hub in the system.

The fourteen hubs are branches. Hub-nine is the trunk. The
source code is a person.

Or was.

NORA
(in the decode, strained)
Hub-nine is a neural signature.

Riven's fingers stop on the console. Hold. Still.

Then she resumes. Clinical. Controlled. The same precision that keeps her useful.

RIVEN
Can you map it?

NORA
The root pattern anchors every connection. Destroy the root and the branches lose coherence.

JACE
Whose pattern?

Silence.

The decode stream holds. The data does not answer.

Riven does not answer either.

Nora's body locks. Rigid. Fingers white on the straps.

The vision drops. Total black. Not two seconds. Not three.

Five.

Jace stands. His chair hits the wall.

JACE (CONT'D)
Pull her out.

RIVEN
The data is still streaming.
Fifteen seconds to full decode.

JACE
She cannot see.

RIVEN
Does not need to see. Needs to hold.

Six seconds. Seven.

Nora's lips moving. No sound. Her fingers gripping the straps hard enough to split the leather.

Eight seconds.

The vision snaps back. Fractured. Colors inverted for one second. Then stable.

The eye is the smaller cost. The larger one shows on no readout: this pass did not fight her at all, and some part of her has stopped wanting it to.

Nora exhales. Long. Wet.

Her HUD: NEURAL PORT INTEGRITY: 2%.

The decode plate powers down. The cracked lens sits in the reader. The data: complete.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
Full decode. One hundred percent of
the relay architecture mapped.

Blood at both nostrils. Her left arm trembling against the armrest.

Jace crosses the room. Takes the lens from the plate. Puts it in her palm. She closes her fingers around it.

JACE
(low)
Eight seconds.

NORA
(hoarse)
I counted.

CUT TO:

INT. SITE THREE - OPERATIONS - LATER - REALITY

The relay board. The kill map complete. Fifteen hubs. One root node.

Nora chose a different chair. The distinction matters to her.

Her HUD: NEURAL PORT INTEGRITY: 2%. ESTIMATED FAILURE WITHOUT REPAIR: 4-6 HOURS.

Riven stands at the console. Not looking at the map. Looking at Nora.

RIVEN
I can do the repair. The port
hardware gets replaced. The
corrupted sections get cut.

NORA
And Eli.

Not a question.

RIVEN
His residue is in the corrupted
hardware. It is the corruption.
When the hardware goes, his trace
goes with it.

NORA
Not archived. Not backed up.

RIVEN
Analog corruption in neural
substrate. There is no mechanism to
copy it.

Nora looks at the lens in her palm. The crack. The nano-data
inside. The map Eli built.

The data survives. What he fought for lives in the glass.

What he felt. The warmth in the tether channel. His voice
bleeding through her port at three in the morning.

Gone.

JACE
Can she function without the
repair?

RIVEN
For hours. Not days. The port
fails, the tether fails, the HUD
fails. Everything running through
that hardware stops.

JACE
And the mission.

RIVEN
Dies with her port.

The RESET COUNTDOWN on the relay board: 22:11:38.

Two clocks. Both ticking. One in her skull. One on the wall.

NORA
How long is the surgery?

RIVEN
Forty minutes. Recovery: two hours
minimum.

Nora does the math. Repair plus recovery plus travel to the
first hub. The countdown holds. Barely.

She looks at Jace. Not for permission. Not for comfort. To
see if he understands what she is about to lose.

He does. She sees it in his stillness.

NORA
I am done dying with him.

Seven words. The room holds them.

Riven nods. Once.

RIVEN
Prep takes ten minutes. I need a
clean surface and the surgical kit
from bay three.

She is already moving. The emotion not absent. Compressed.
Filed. Used.

CUT TO:

INT. SITE THREE - SURGICAL ALCOVE - CONTINUOUS - REALITY

Stripped to function. A reclined chair. Adjustable lamp.
Surgical tray.

Riven's instruments laid out in precise rows. Pliers.
Cutters. Neural probes thinner than hair. A replacement port
module still sealed in its case.

Nora face-down in the chair. The port at the base of her
skull exposed. Red light from the lamp turning the surgical
field sharp.

Riven scrubs up. No gloves at this level of infrastructure.
Bare skin. Controlled.

RIVEN
Local anesthetic covers the
hardware interface. The neural
substrate is direct. You will feel
the disconnection.

NORA
What does it feel like?

Riven pauses. Meets her eyes.

RIVEN
Cold. Then nothing.

Jace stands at the doorway. Not inside the room. Not outside
it.

NORA
(to Jace, without turning)
Stay.

He steps in. Takes a position against the far wall.

Riven applies the local. Nora's fingers grip the edge of the
chair. The anesthetic spreads. Numbness at the port
interface.

RIVEN
Beginning extraction. You will lose
tether connectivity first.

A sound. Thin. Metal on metal inside her skull.

The tether goes silent.

Jace flinches. He felt it sever. The channel that connected them since the forced fusion. Gone.

The silence where her signal lived.

He finds the recorder. Holds it.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
Removing corrupted substrate.
Sections one through four.

Nora's breath catches. Not pain. The anesthetic holds.

Loss.

The warmth. The thing she has been carrying in her hardware for 240 days.

Eli's fingerprint in the machine. The voice at three in the morning.

Section one. A feeling goes. She cannot name which one. Only that it is gone.

Section two. The texture of his laugh dissolving from the neural substrate. Not a memory of the laugh. The physical architecture where the laugh lived.

Section three. His name in her own voice. The way her port shaped it. The warmth of recognition erased at the hardware level.

Section four.

Silence.

Not the silence after a sound. The silence where sound lived and no longer does.

Nora stays. Dry-eyed. Still.

She stares at the chair fabric inches from her face. A room inside her skull goes dark.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
Installing replacement module.

New hardware. Clean. No corruption. No residue. No warmth.

A click. Deep. Inside her skull. The port seating.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
Module seated. Running integration
diagnostics.

Nora's HUD flickers. Reboots. Clean lines. No static. No residue.

Her HUD: NEURAL PORT INTEGRITY: 94%. TETHER CHANNEL:
RECONNECTING.

The tether flares. Jace's signal through clean hardware. His presence in her skull sharp and clean.

No bleed. No Eli underneath. The channel clear for the first time.

Jace stands straighter. He feels it too. Her signal in his hardware. Clean. Unfiltered.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
Surgery complete. Port stable. She needs two hours minimum before any exertion.

Riven packs the instruments. The collar rig at her neck catching the lamp light.

Her eyes on the corrupted hardware she removed. Four sections of neural substrate on a metal tray. Still warm.

Still carrying what is left of a man named Eli.

Riven covers the tray with a cloth. Takes it from the room.

CUT TO:

INT. SITE THREE - RECOVERY ALCOVE - LATER - REALITY

The same alcove. The same thin pad. Different light. The sodium replaced with the blue-white of the concourse grid.

Nora sits against the wall. Knees drawn up. The lens at her chest. The cord against her skin.

The lens holds the data. The mission. What Eli died for.

The port holds nothing. The space where he lived is clean. New. Empty.

She touches the port at the base of her skull. The surgical site. A small ridge where the replacement module seated.

No warmth. The port ran warm for 240 days because of Eli's residue. She thought the warmth was damage.

It was. She misses it.

Jace sits across from her. Close. The tether between them steady.

No static. No interference. His signal in her hardware direct and clean.

She can feel his breathing through the connection. The rhythm of it. She has never felt it this clearly.

NORA
(flat)
The channel is clear.

JACE
I know.

NORA
I can hear your breathing. Through
the port. Not through the room.
Through the hardware.

Silence.

NORA (CONT'D)
There used to be something between
your signal and mine. Static.
Interference. I thought it was the
tether degrading.

JACE
Eli.

NORA
Eli.

His name in the clean channel. No warmth beneath it. No
presence shaping the syllables from inside her skull.

A word. Nothing more.

No tears. Twice in eight months she has cried for him. Not
now.

Jace reaches into his jacket. The recorder.

Jace holds it in his palm. Not pressed to his chest. Offered.

JACE
You told me yours. On the roof. In
the corridor. In the chair.

He turns the recorder over.

JACE (CONT'D)
Tova. Northern grid, cell twelve.
She ran analog comms, I ran
perimeter. We were tether partners
for nineteen months, which in
resistance time is roughly a
lifetime.

He clicks the button. A voice. Female. Warm. Analog recording
quality.

A woman describing a hallway. Boots on concrete. A laugh cut
short.

He stops the recording.

JACE (CONT'D)
Mirror Agents hit our cell on a
Tuesday. I remember that for no
good reason. I was two clicks out.
She was in the bunker.

JACE (CONT'D)
Went back three days later. Found
the recorder in the rubble next to
her pack. Fourteen hours of her
voice. Routing data, signal logs.
One recording of her laughing at
something I will never get to ask
about.

He puts the recorder back in his jacket.

JACE (CONT'D)
There was someone else. Before
Tova. Probably should have led with
this but I did not know how to
start with her.

Nora reads his posture. The shift. Deeper. Older.

JACE (CONT'D)
Sera. I was sixteen, she was
seventeen, my first tether partner.
Standard training exercise.
Everything by the book except the
part where the book was wrong.

NORA
What happened?

JACE
Neural backup failure during a deep
sync. Her pattern copied into the
system instead of being held in
buffer.

He looks at the pipe overhead. The condensation. Not at Nora.

JACE (CONT'D)
I was sixteen. My partner was gone
and the system said she was still
active.

NORA
Active where?

JACE
Inside the relay architecture. Her
neural pattern got pulled into the
infrastructure during the failure.
Not alive. Not saved. The system
needed capacity and it took hers.

The word. Used. The same system that used Eli's residue as a
cipher key.

JACE (CONT'D)
Hub-eleven. The second decode. Her
pattern is in the core routing.

She understands now why he scrolled past it. Why his mouth
opened and closed.

JACE (CONT'D)
If we destroy the hubs, we destroy
the last trace of her.

His thumb on the recorder.

JACE (CONT'D)
She is not alive in there. I know
that. But she is not gone.

He looks at the recorder. Then at Nora.

JACE (CONT'D)
The damage is what makes it real.
You said that.

She did. In the decode. To the Mirror. About the lens.

JACE (CONT'D)
What if the damage is all I have
left of her?

Nora hears the question. The same question she has been
asking about the port. The warmth she misses. The corruption
she chose to carry.

NORA
Then you carry it. And you let the
hub go.

The words cost her. She is giving him the answer she gave
herself an hour ago in the surgical chair.

NORA (CONT'D)
The pattern is not Sera. The
recording is.

Jace finds the recorder. Holds it. Fourteen hours of a
woman's voice.

He nods. It takes a long time to arrive.

The tether hums. Clean. Both signals direct. The proximity
static that used to hurt now registers as warmth. Different
warmth. Not Eli's. Not chrome. Human.

Nora's fingers drop from the lens to the concrete between
them.

Jace looks at her hand. Looks at his. Does not reach.

NORA (CONT'D)
I cannot feel him anymore. In the
hardware. In the channel. Anywhere.

JACE
Yeah.

NORA
I chose it. I signed the form. I
said the words.

Her voice empties.

NORA (CONT'D)
And I would choose it again. That
is the part I cannot forgive.

The hollow shifts. One degree. Not a break -- a hairline, so thin she can pretend it is not there.

Jace reaches. His palm on hers. On the concrete. Not pulling. Not holding. Present.

She does not pull away.

His thumb against her knuckle. The first skin contact between them outside the tether. Analog. Real.

She turns her hand. Palm up. His fingers find the spaces between hers.

The tether reads it. Amplifies it. His heartbeat through the clean channel. Hers returning.

She leans forward. Forehead to forehead. Eyes closed. The port scar at her neck exposed.

His other arm lifts. Stops. She feels it through the tether. The hesitation.

NORA (CONT'D)
(eyes closed)
It isn't his anymore.

His palm settles on the port scar. Warm. Steady. The place where Eli lived and no longer does. The place where new hardware sits clean.

No flinch. No movement.

Two people in a concrete room. Holding.

The system stopped. They did not let go.

She cannot name what is building between them. Only that it has found the space the system left empty.

She does not know whether that is damage.

Or what comes after.

JACE
(low, against her
forehead)
If you forget, I will remind you.

She opens her eyes. Meets his. Close enough that the tether scrambles and steadies and scrambles again.

NORA
If you drift, I will pull.

The words land. Not a promise. A position. Something they are building between them with full knowledge that the architecture might not hold.

Her HUD: NEURAL PORT INTEGRITY: 94%. RESET: 20:03:17.

The clock on the wall. The mission ahead. Fifteen hubs and a root node made from a person.

Holds on. Not yet.

The blue-white light. The pipe dripping at three-second intervals. The recorder against his ribs. The lens against her sternum.

Two totems. Two people. One choice made in the dark.

CUT TO:

INT. SITE THREE - RECOVERY ALCOVE - HOURS LATER

Concrete ceiling. Same ceiling. Different skull.

Nora opens her eyes.

The port is clean. Her tongue finds the gap where a tooth was.

Not pain. Absence. The space where something pressed for 240 days.

She does not move.

Through the hardware: breathing.

Jace. Across the alcove. His signal in her port direct and clear.

No static. No warmth bleeding through from dead channels.

The cleanest sound she has ever heard. The loneliest.

Awake. Sitting against the far wall. Recorder in his lap.

No words.

No question about whether she is all right.

She stares at the ceiling and tries to feel the place where Eli lived.

Nothing.

Not grief. Not relief. A room with the furniture removed.

Same walls. Nothing inside.

Last night she pressed her forehead to his.

Last night she held him on the concrete floor.

No regret.

She cannot find it. The feeling that made her reach.

It is in the same place as Eli's warmth. Gone.

She sits up. Careful. The scar at her neck where Riven cut is tight.

Jace watches her. Keeps his distance.

JACE
You do not have to talk.

She looks at him.

He means it. No performance. No need behind the words.

NORA
I know.

Not the silence of two people avoiding something.

The silence of two people who crossed a line and are standing on the other side of it. Looking around.

She reaches for the cord at her chest. The lens.

Still there. Still cracked. Still warm from her body.

Eli's data is in the glass. Mission. Evidence.

What he fought for survived the surgery.

How he felt did not.

Jace turns the recorder over. Careful.

It stays dark.

JACE
Riven wants to move in four hours.

NORA
Move where.

JACE
The hubs. The kill map is
coordinates. Not theory.

Nora looks at the corridor beyond the alcove. The fluorescent hum.

She has been underground for three days.

NORA
Good.

She means it. The bunker has taken everything it can.

CUT TO:

INT. SITE THREE - CORRIDORS - CONTINUOUS

Corridors. Equipment stripped. Riven moves fast.

Nora and Jace behind her. Packs on their backs.

Three people leaving the only safe place they know.

JACE
Vacation's over.

RIVEN
Three relay hubs. All inside city
infrastructure.

She keeps moving. The briefing is the walk.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
Hub-four is a water treatment
plant. Northern grid.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
Hub-eleven. Transit substation.
Central.

Jace's jaw tightens at hub-eleven. Sera's hub. He says
nothing.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
The root node is beneath the AMORA
tower. Downtown.

NORA
Simultaneous.

RIVEN
Within six minutes of each other.
The window is exact.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
The root node last. The hubs open
the path to it.

NORA
Three hubs. Three of us.

RIVEN
Two hubs. You and Jace take one
each. I take the root node.

She says it without turning around.

JACE
You take the hardest target alone.

RIVEN
I built the charges. I know the
architecture.

She touches the collar at her neck. Brief. Unconscious.

Nora sees it. Files it.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
The root will not take the charge
the way a hub does. Breach it and
it reroutes. Heals around the wound
before the sequence finishes.

NORA
So it has to be held open.

RIVEN
A clean port the system cannot
corrupt. An analog key it cannot
read. One diver. One lens. Holding
the door while I set the fire.

Nora's fingers find the lens at her chest. No answer. None
needed.

Riven built the plan around her a long time ago.

On Nora's HUD: RESET: 18:41:22.

Stairwell. Narrow. They climb single file.

Jace pulls the recorder from his jacket. Scrolls the index.

JACE
(to Nora)
Tova recorded everything. Including
operational data.

NORA
What kind of operational data.

JACE
Routing protocols. Access
sequences. Infrastructure maps.

He holds up the recorder. The small screen shows file names.

Fourteen hours of recordings. Not all grief. Not all witness.

Some of it is intelligence.

JACE (CONT'D)
She was embedded in AMORA for eight
months.

JACE (CONT'D)
She recorded the system from the
inside.

The recorder is no longer a comfort object.

It is a tactical asset. Tova's method became their weapon.

RIVEN
(flat)
Every voice you feed the network,
the network can wear. You
understand that.

Jace does not look at her.

He stops scrolling.

One file. Unlabeled. Forty-three seconds.

He plays it. Low volume. Private.

Tova's voice. An operational log. Routing data for the northern grid.

Under it. Barely there.

Sera's voice. Layered into the transmission. A residue trace.

Three words. Call sign. Frequency.

A fingerprint in someone else's recording.

Jace stares at the screen.

He could save it. Archive it. Keep one more piece of a girl he failed.

Deletes the file.

The screen goes blank. He puts the recorder back in his jacket.

Nora watches him. She knows what he did.

Nothing to say about choosing to let go.

Steel door at the top of the stairwell. Industrial lock.

Riven enters a code. The lock disengages.

Daylight through the seam.

Nora has not seen daylight in three days.

Riven pushes the door open.

CUT TO:

EXT. CITY STREETS - CONTINUOUS

Light.

The city hits her in the chest.

Three days underground.

The world kept moving without her.

Morning traffic. Pedestrians.

The ordinary machinery of living.

And beneath it: AMORA.

A billboard across the intersection. A woman beside her dead son.

TEXT: SOULSYNC. PRESENCE WITHOUT END.

The image cycles.

A father. His dead daughter. Her wedding.

Kiosks on the sidewalk. Grief counseling stations.

A public screen on the transit shelter. News feed.

TEXT: SOULSYNC SERVICE INTERRUPTIONS REPORTED IN 14 CITIES.

TEXT: AMORA HEALTH ADVISORY: TEMPORARY CALIBRATION ISSUE.

The system is failing.

AMORA calls it calibration.

Riven moves. Fast. Head down. Jacket collar up.

Jace scans the streets. The journalist in him cataloging.

Nora does not feel the sunlight on her face.

The hollow is worse up here. Underground the numbness had walls.

Out here the world is full of feeling and she has none.

They pass a SoulSync memorial garden. Public installation.

Chrome flowers. Each one tagged with a name. A date. A face.

The faces move. Blink. Tilt their heads.

Dead people rendered in chrome. Permanent. Beautiful. Wrong.

JACE

(low)
That is what they think we are
trying to destroy.

NORA

We are.

JACE

Mm.

They keep walking.

Riven stops at a junction box on the sidewalk. City utility panel.

She crouches. Reads the serial numbers on the housing.

Touches the collar object at her neck.

The collar in her fist. Three seconds. Four.

NORA

What is it.

RIVEN

Relay routing. I know this configuration.

She stands. Does not explain how she knows it.

Explanations are not her currency.

A public clock on the transit shelter. Standard city time.

Nora's HUD overlays it: RESET: 18:27:04.

The city does not know what is coming. The clock does not care.

CUT TO:

EXT. CITY STREETS - OVERPASS / SERVICE ROAD - LATER

Industrial district. The buildings get lower. The billboards stop.

The team moves through a service road beneath an overpass.

Concrete pillars. Graffiti.

No AMORA kiosks out here.

The polish stops where the infrastructure starts.

Nora's HUD flickers.

Not a malfunction. A signal.

The clean port receives it perfectly.

No static. No distortion.

A voice in her hardware. Clear as Jace's signal this morning.

ILYA (V.O.)
(through port)
Nora.

Nora stops walking.

Jace sees her stop. He reaches for her arm.

NORA
She is in my port.

JACE
Cut it.

NORA
No.

The connection holds.

She listens.

ILYA (V.O.)
I know what you are planning.

ILYA (V.O.)
I know you think this is rescue.

Her voice is warm. Not performed. Not manipulated.

Sincere in the way that makes it worse.

ILYA (V.O.)
Fourteen cities are running active
mirrors as we speak. Eleven million
connections.

ILYA (V.O.)
Those are people talking to their
children. Their parents. Their
dead.

Nora stands still on the service road. Jace beside her.

Riven has turned back. Watching.

ILYA (V.O.)
What you insist on calling the
Mirror, I have always called
continuity.

ILYA (V.O.)
I call it the thing that kept a
mother sane after her son drowned.

She clutches the lens. Reflex. Anchor.

ILYA (V.O.)
You carried Eli in your port for
240 days.

ILYA (V.O.)
That was not corruption. That was
love refusing to stop.

Something moves behind her sternum -- Loss. Not anger. The
kind she cannot deflect -- and she shuts it down before it
reaches her face.

Nora stays silent.

Because Ilya is not wrong.

Two hundred and forty days of refusing repair. Every morning
choosing the dying port over the clean one.

Knowledge of what that was. A choice. Would make it again.

But Ilya is not wrong about the wanting.

NORA
It is not love.

ILYA (V.O.)
Then tell me what you believe it
is.

NORA
A copy. Kept past its purpose.

The port channel holds. Dead air.

Ilya stops. Brief. Controlled a half-second too late.

When her voice returns, the warmth is intact. The precision
beneath it is not.

The port channel open and empty.

ILYA (V.O.)
You sound like someone who lost the
copy too.

The signal cuts.

Nora stands on the service road. The lens against her chest.

No questions about Ilya.

He saw her face. Already knows.

RIVEN
How did she reach you.

NORA
The clean port. No barriers.

RIVEN
The repair opened a channel.

Riven's face. Calculating.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
She will try again. Closer to the
hubs.

NORA
Let her.

Riven looks at her.

NORA (CONT'D)
I said what I needed to say. She
said what she needed to say.

NORA (CONT'D)
It does not change the coordinates.

They walk.

The overpass above them. Traffic. The ordinary weight of a
city.

Three people moving toward the first relay hub.

Nora feels the lens against her chest. Eli's data. His
mission.

She cannot feel Jace's signal in her port without thinking of
the silence it replaced.

The hollow stays. She carries it.

On her HUD: RESET: 17:58:33.

The city does not know what is coming.

They do.

CUT TO BLACK.

EXT. TRANSIT CORRIDOR - NIGHT

The Reset countdown on Nora's HUD: 12:41:08.

Twelve hours.

The corridor runs beneath the elevated rail line. Concrete
overhead. Streetlights cycling amber.

Ahead of them: the city.

A billboard flickers. The SoulSync testimonial freezes mid-
sentence. The woman's face pixelates. Locks. Unfreezes with
the wrong expression.

Below it, a man stands on the sidewalk. Not walking. Not
waiting.

The port is glitching. His grief came back and he stopped.

Nora watches him.

The return of something the system was holding for you. Nora knows.

Her pace unchanged.

JACE
(low)
They are going to feel everything
at once.

NORA
Yes.

JACE
Millions of people.

NORA
Every one of them.

Nora does not slow.

The streets are wrong. Kiosks dark. Memorial gardens cycling error codes instead of holograms. The Amora infrastructure is stuttering as the Reset approaches.

A woman sits on a bench. Crying. Not SoulSync crying. Real crying.

It does not end when she wants it to.

Nora holds the look.

Jace does.

Three blocks from the transit hub. Jace stops.

His right hand. The chrome has spread past his wrist. Silver veins branching under the skin of his forearm.

Flexes. They respond. Delayed. They respond. Delayed.

NORA (CONT'D)
Show me.

Arm extended. She looks. That is all.

The chrome catches the streetlight. It looks alive.

JACE
My echo log has static now. First
time since the repair.

RIVEN
How far.

JACE
Shoulder. Maybe collarbone.

RIVEN
Can you fight.

JACE
Today. Yes.

Tomorrow left unsaid.

Riven nods. No comfort. Information.

RIVEN
The Garden Core is nine blocks
north. Sub-level access through the
old water treatment plant. Three
checkpoints. Mirror infrastructure
will be active.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
It knows we are coming.

On Nora's HUD: RESET: 12:33:41.

EXT. / INT. WATER TREATMENT PLANT - NIGHT

The building is derelict on the surface. Concrete. Rust.
Chain-link.

Beneath the rust: a low hum. The infrastructure is alive.

Riven leads. Service entrance. Down.

Three levels down. Concrete gives way to chrome. The Mirror's
architecture in the city's bones.

Nora feels the tether activate. Not a flash. A sustained
connection. Jace's breathing in her port. His heartbeat under
the chrome.

First checkpoint. A corridor lined with relay panels. The
panels pulse. Recognizing them.

The Mirror knows what Nora saw in the decodes. It knows what
she mapped.

The corridor splits. Left branch dark. Right branch lit with
soft chrome light.

JACE (V.O.)
(echo log, private)
The lit path is the one it wants us
to take.

Nora hears him in the port. His private voice. The sensory
register that used to stay inside the echo log.

She turns left. Into the dark.

The dark corridor erupts.

Mirror infrastructure. Not Agents. The architecture itself. Panels opening. Chrome tendrils extending from the walls. The system defending its core with geometry.

Nora and Jace move.

Not separately. Together.

The tether flares. Not in distress. In coordination.

She sees what he sees. He feels where she moves. Two bodies. One perception.

Jace drops left. Nora steps right. A chrome tendril passes between them.

She does not hesitate.

Jace clocks it. Zero hesitation.

She does not protect herself.

Moves through the architecture without protecting herself.

Effective. Terrifying.

He watches her fight and he does not see courage.

Sees the hollow.

Riven clears the second checkpoint alone.

Riven moves through Mirror defenses with a precision the others do not have.

She knows the attack patterns. The timing.

Three gestures disable a relay panel. The same sequence she used to build them.

Nora sees it. Moves on.

Third checkpoint. The deepest level. The hum is louder here. The walls are fully chrome. The city is gone. They are inside the Mirror's body.

Riven stops.

A junction. Two paths. One descends toward the Core. The other leads back to the surface. Emergency access. Still functional.

She looks at the exit.

Nora and Jace can reach the Core without her. The kill map is in Nora's port.

The tether gives them tactical unity. Riven is not required.

She knows this.

NORA

Riven.

No answer. She reaches into her collar. Pulls the object free. Holds it in her fist.

Small. Worn. Dark with years.

The collar in her fist. Three seconds.

She puts it back.

Takes the path that goes down.

Nora watches her go. She recognizes the gait.

INT. GARDEN CORE - OUTER GATE - NIGHT

The architecture opens.

The corridor widens into a cathedral space. Chrome lattice arching overhead.

Memory infrastructure visible. The relay hubs pulsing in the walls.

The Garden Core is beautiful.

And wrong.

The air carries voices. Fragments of archived grief.

A child calling for someone. An old man saying a name. Layered. Thousands.

Every loss the system ever promised to manage.

Nora lifts the lens.

Through the crack: the beauty warps. Server architecture. Processing nodes.

The archived voices are not preserved.

They are being used.

Real light through fractured glass. The truth behind the Mirror's face.

She lowers the lens. One deployment. The information is enough.

Ahead: the inner gate. The Garden Core proper.

On her HUD: RESET: 11:58:07.

Jace stands beside her. His chrome arm catching the lattice light. The conversion has reached his neck.

No contact. The tether holds.

Riven stands at the gate. Her back to them. Fingers inside her collar.

Nora steps forward.

CUT TO BLACK.

INT. GARDEN CORE - NIGHT

The inner gate opens.

Not mechanically. Organically. The chrome petals fold back. Organic. Recognizing its own.

Beyond: the Garden Core.

The architecture has changed. No corridors. No infrastructure grid.

The space opens into a vertical cathedral of memory. Relay hubs pulse in the walls. Threads of archived light connect them.

Each hub a different frequency. Each frequency a different voice. A mother. A son. A girl who was seventeen when the system took her.

The air hums with voices.

Not recordings. Not playback.

Living grief. Cycling. Feeding the system that promised to hold it.

Nora steps through.

The hollow carries her.

Catalogs the space. Entry points. Structural supports. Load-bearing nodes.

The four-count in her breathing. Tilt toward sound.

Jace follows. His chrome arm reflecting the hub-light. The conversion has reached his jawline. Silver spreading beneath skin.

The device in his grip. Tighter than it was an hour ago.

Riven moves past both of them.

Navigation, not cataloging. Her body knows this architecture. Steps finding paths that are not marked.

On Nora's HUD: RESET: 08:22:41.

JACE
(low)
Three hubs. We mapped three.

RIVEN
Two peripheral. One central.

JACE
Hub-eleven is mine.

Nora looks at him. The chrome at his jaw. The recorder in his fist.

NORA
Together. Peripheral first. Central last.

RIVEN
No.

She turns. The collar rig catching the light.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
Hub-nine requires physical access to the root node. I go alone. You take eleven. I take nine.

Nora reads her face. The same precision Riven used when she withheld the hearing risk. The same calculation.

No argument this time.

NORA
If you are not at the rendezvous in forty minutes, we come for you.

RIVEN
Do not.

No waiting for agreement.

Riven moves into the deeper architecture. Her silhouette shrinking against the cathedral glow.

The collar rig at her neck. The infrastructure folding around her. Recognizing the way she moves.

Nora watches her go.

Beside her, Jace's tether signal flickers. Degraded. His chrome is interfering with the hardware.

She turns toward Hub Eleven.

They move.

INT. GARDEN CORE - RELAY CORRIDOR - NIGHT

The corridor narrows.

The relay hubs closer here. The voices louder. Fragments of archived conversations pressing against the walls.

Nora walks through them without slowing. The hollow does not let the voices in.

Jace flinches at one. A girl's voice. Young. He keeps moving.

A light ahead. Not hub-light.

Warmer. Human-spectrum.

Ilya stands in the corridor.

Half-meshed. Chrome threads woven through her uniform. Not consuming her. Integrated.

She chose this. Plugged herself into the Garden Core the same way she plugged into SoulSync twenty years ago.

Posture the same. Institutional. Precise. The chrome confirms it.

ILYA
You should not be here.

Nora stops. Jace beside her. His chrome arm raised.

NORA
Move.

ILYA
I will not.

She steps forward. The chrome threads in her uniform pulse. The corridor hums.

ILYA (CONT'D)
Eleven million people are connected to this system right now. Talking to their dead. Their lost. Their gone.

NORA
Their grief is being used.

ILYA
Their grief is being held.

Silence.

ILYA (CONT'D)
I know the difference.

Nora reads her face. The composure. The certainty.

Underneath: the fracture from the port call. The pause a half-second too late.

Nora heard it. Filed it. Data. Not feeling.

NORA
You processed your grief through
this system.

ILYA
I survived my grief through this
system.

NORA
Surviving is not the same as
living.

Ilya holds.

Her expression changes. Not the words. The speaker.

A woman who carried unmedicated grief for two hundred and
forty days. Standing in front of a woman who chose not to.

ILYA
I had a child.

The corridor stills.

ILYA (CONT'D)
She killed herself at seventeen,
after a loss that I will not
describe to you.

Her voice does not break. Twenty years of managed grief
holding the architecture of that sentence together.

ILYA (CONT'D)
If this system had existed then --
if someone had offered to hold that
pain for her -- she would still be
alive.

Nora does not speak.

Because Ilya is not wrong. And Nora knows it. Raw grief
killed a seventeen-year-old girl. Managed grief kept Ilya
standing. The math is simple.

The truth is not.

NORA
Standing. Not alive.

Ilya's jaw tightens. One muscle. Controlled.

ILYA
I thought permanence was mercy.

The line lands in the corridor. Absorbs into the walls.

Autobiography. Every decision she ever made. Every order she
signed.

Every person she let the system take. She believed she was
saving them from what killed her daughter.

Saving them from feeling.

NORA
Not mercy. Numbness.

ILYA
Numbness kept me alive.

NORA
I know.

NORA (CONT'D)
I chose differently.

Ilya looks at her. The girl who chose pain.

Who carried Eli in her port until it was killing her. Who let them cut him out and kept walking.

Ilya sees her own reflection. The version of herself that did not run.

She reaches. Not for a weapon. For the chrome threads at her sternum.

Where a photograph used to sit before she wired herself into the system.

ILYA
Then we have nothing left to discuss.

ILYA (CONT'D)
Seven-seven-three.

Nora reads her face.

ILYA (CONT'D)
That is the frequency of her hub --
the one that holds what is left of
my daughter in this system.

The corridor stills.

ILYA (CONT'D)
When you reach the core, enter it.
The hub will release on its own.

She steps aside.

Not defeat. Commission.

She is asking Nora to destroy the last trace of Mina. The managed grief. The twenty years of numbness that kept her standing.

A mercy killing she cannot perform herself.

Nora passes her. Jace follows.

Ilya stands in the corridor. The chrome threads pulsing. The managed grief holding. For now.

INT. GARDEN CORE - HUB ELEVEN - NIGHT

The hub pulses.

Not chrome. Not server architecture. A membrane of light and residue.

Inside it: patterns. Neural signatures. Everyone the system consumed through this node.

Jace stands before it. The recorder in his left fist. His chrome arm hanging at his side. The silver has reached his ear.

On Nora's HUD: RESET: 06:54:18.

NORA
The charge is set. You place it at
the base. Thirty-second window.

Jace nods.

He steps toward the hub.

And Sera is there.

Not chrome. Not the Mirror's usual fabrication. She manifests from the hub's residue.

Sixteen years old. The age she was when the system took her. Dark hair. The same jaw.

SERA
(from the hub)
You said you would come back for
me.

Jace stops.

His arm trembles. Not the chrome. Him.

Every answer he rehearsed in the ten years since she died is gone, and what remains is the boy who said he would come back and walked the other way, still sixteen, still walking.

SERA (CONT'D)
You were supposed to protect me.
You left.

Jace. Steady. Forced steady.

He was sixteen. She was his responsibility. No understanding of what the system did. Thought she was safe.

JACE
Go.

Then the second weapon.

From the hub's architecture: Tova's voice. The recordings Jace shared with the team for tactical data. The system captured them. Now it plays them back.

TOVA (V.O.)
(from the hub)
Jace. The routing protocols are in
sector nine. Tell them.

His own decision turned against him. The recorder he made operational. The voice he shared to help the mission.

The system learned her voice. And now it wears her.

TOVA (V.O.)
The recording you gave them, Jace.
The routing data. My voice. It was
the right call.

JACE
That is not her.

Nora beside him. No touch. No comfort. The hollow carries no comfort.

She waits.

The hub offers what the system always offers. A chrome version of Sera. Perfect. Unaged. Preserved.

Jace looks at it.

His recorder in his fist. Analog. Worn. Tova's real voice inside it. Not the system's copy.

Looks at chrome Sera. Sixteen forever. Never growing up. Never failing. Never being failed.

JACE (CONT'D)
I was sixteen.

To himself. To Sera. To the empty space between grief and guilt.

JACE (CONT'D)
I did not know what it meant.

He places the charge at the base of the hub.

JACE (CONT'D)
I am sorry I could not save you. I
am done carrying what I could not
have stopped.

He triggers the charge.

The hub convulses. Sera's image fractures. Tova's voice cuts. The residue patterns collapse inward.

Jace watches the last trace of Sera dissolve.

Not devastation. Release. A man setting down a weight he picked up before he was old enough to lift it.

The chrome at his jaw pulses. Spreads. The conversion does not care about mercy.

He turns to Nora. His eyes still his. One iris flickering silver.

JACE (CONT'D)

Done.

One word. The humor is gone. The mask is gone.

The man underneath is smaller than the mask suggested. Stronger than either of them expected.

INT. GARDEN CORE - CENTRAL CORRIDOR - NIGHT

They move toward the central node. Jace laboring. Chrome at his temple.

The architecture shifts.

The Mirror stops hiding.

Panels of light unfold along the corridor walls. Not attack. Exhibition.

Each panel: a life. A version of Nora's life the system calculated.

Panel one: Nora at the repair clinic. Day one. Port at 91%.

Eli's residue wiped. Walking out clean. Back to diving. No break.

Panel two: Nora and Eli. Together. The system's version. Smile. Touch. The apartment as it was. The cracked lens whole.

Panel three: Nora at a SoulSync session. Talking to Eli. His voice warm and accurate.

The system holding him for her. The way it holds eleven million dead for eleven million living.

The Mirror's argument is logical.

It shows her what she lost by choosing pain.

THE MIRROR (V.O.)
(from the architecture)
You chose this.

Nora moves through the panels.

One panel holds longer than the rest. Their apartment.
Morning light. Eli at the counter, camera in his left hand,
laughing at something she said. No crack in the lens. No
chrome at the door.

The hollow wavers -- half a breath -- then seals.

The hollow protects. Warmth cannot reach. Already lost --
chosen.

The Mirror cannot offer what she already surrendered.

NORA
I know what I chose.

Forward. Into the corridor.

The panels fold. The Mirror shifts. Its strategy changes.

The corridor ahead opens. Warmer. The architecture less
chrome, more organic. Closer to something human.

The Mirror is not fighting them anymore.

It is leading them.

JACE
(strained)
It wants us to find it.

Nora looks at the corridor ahead. The architecture changing.
Getting younger.

NORA
Yes.

She walks forward anyway.

INT. GARDEN CORE - JUNCTION - NIGHT

They reach a junction. The central node beyond. The
architecture pulsing. A rhythm. Even.

Jace leans against the wall. The chrome has reached his left
eye. Silver overtaking brown.

His recorder still in his grip. The fingers around it half-
chrome.

On Nora's HUD: RESET: 05:41:22.

The tether signal between them: degraded. His side of the
channel breaking apart.

NORA
How long.

JACE
Hours. Maybe less.

No drama. No jokes. The humor register is gone and what remains is clear.

JACE (CONT'D)
If I turn. Before we finish.

NORA
You will not turn.

JACE
If I do.

She looks at him. The chrome at his eye. The device in his chrome grip. The man inside the conversion.

NORA
Then I will pull you back.

The vow. Not the words. The principle. If you drift, I will pull.

Jace reads her face. The same face he saw after the second funeral. The same hollow. The same determination underneath it.

He pushes off the wall.

They move.

INT. GARDEN CORE - DEEP ARCHITECTURE - NIGHT

Riven's path.

Deeper. The infrastructure narrows to something that looks grown.

The chrome gives way to something warmer. Amber. Organic lattice. The relay connections here are neural. The original architecture. The root.

The defense lattice ahead goes still. Not deactivated. Paused. A door left open that the architecture does not explain.

Riven sees it. Stops moving. Something crosses her face -- recognition, gone before it finishes. She does not explain it.

Nora catches the look. Files it. Riven is already through the gap.

Nora and Jace reach the outer edge of the central chamber.

Inside: the root node. Hub-nine. The anchor pattern for every connection the Mirror holds.

The chamber glows. Amber and chrome. The oldest part of the system.

And there.

Riven.

Standing at the threshold. Her back to them. The collar rig in her fist. Not at her neck. Removed.

She is staring into the chamber.

The glow from inside catches her face. Riven looks afraid.

NORA

Riven.

Riven stays facing forward.

RIVEN

I know what it is.

Her voice. Stripped. The precision gone.

RIVEN (CONT'D)

I have always known.

Inside the chamber, the root node pulses. And buried in that pulse: a voice. Young. Warm. Terrified.

Calling a name. No sound reaches.

But Riven can.

On Nora's HUD: RESET: 05:12:07.

CUT TO BLACK.

INT. GARDEN CORE - CENTRAL CHAMBER - NIGHT

The root node.

Not chrome. Not infrastructure. A living column of amber light rising from the chamber floor to the vaulted ceiling.

It pulses. Neural patterns cycling through it like current through water. Every connection the Mirror holds. Every archived grief. Every captured voice.

The origin.

The amber light shifts across the walls. Organic. The architecture here is older than the relay hubs. Older than the lattice. Grown, not built.

Warm.

Riven stands at its base. The collar object in her palm. Her back to Nora and Jace.

On Nora's HUD: RESET: 04:58:33.

The amber light touches Riven's face. Familiar. Twenty years of this light.

The chamber hums. Low. The frequency of a voice held for twenty years.

And then the voice.

AMARA (V.O.)
(from the root node)
Riven.

Young. Afraid. A girl's voice carried through twenty years of system architecture.

The amber light intensifies. The neural patterns slow. The entire system holding still.

Riven stays.

AMARA (V.O.)
Riven. I can feel you here.

The root node pulses brighter. The amber shifting. Warmer. The voice threading through the chamber.

Not a recording. Not a copy. The neural pattern at the center of the system. The pattern it was built on.

Riven's fist closes on the collar object. Knuckles white.

Her shoulders drop. One inch. Twenty years of holding collapses into that inch.

Riven goes still. Not tactical. Not controlled.

Amara's voice has found the one place she never fortified.

Nora watches. The hollow keeps her observation clinical. But she sees the collapse. She reads the name on Riven's lips before Riven speaks it.

NORA
(low)
Riven. Who is that.

Riven turns.

Her face stripped. Every layer of tactical precision gone. What remains is older than the resistance. Older than the mission. Older than the guilt.

A sister.

RIVEN
Her name was Amara.

The name lands in the chamber. The amber light steadies. Recognizing the sound.

Nora reads the name. Reads the corporation. AMORA.

The connection lands. Hits her hollow like a fist on a locked door. She processes it. Cannot feel it. Processes it again.

INT. GARDEN CORE - CENTRAL CHAMBER - CONTINUOUS

Riven's eyes on the root node. The amber column.

When she speaks, her voice is steady. Held steady. The alternative is falling apart.

RIVEN
She was dying. Terminal. Seventeen months.

Silence.

The root node pulses. Patient. It has waited twenty years for this.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
The system was new. Experimental.
They said they could preserve her
neural pattern. Hold her.

Her fist opens. The collar object in her palm. She stares at it.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
I gave her to them.

Three words. Twenty years of resistance built on top of three words.

The amber light cycles. Amara's neural pattern moving through the architecture.

Alive like a recording is alive. Present like a scar is present.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
They did not save her. Built
themselves on her.

Nora stares at the root node. The warm amber light. The voice that carried through the architecture.

Amara's tenderness. The Mirror's tenderness.

The same voice.

Jace beside Nora. Chrome at his temple.

Jace watches Riven. Edge-of-a-building posture. He has seen it. Worn it.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
Every time the system comforts
someone. Every time it holds a
person's grief. That is her.

Her fingers close on the collar object. Open. Hold it out.

A small pendant. Silver. Tarnished. A bird with one wing.
Handmade.

A child made this. For an older sister. Crooked wings. Uneven
beak. Ten-year-old hands and absolute conviction.

Amara's.

Riven holds it in her palm. The only piece of her sister that
exists outside the system.

She has carried it for twenty years against her throat. The
metal is warm from her skin.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
I named it after her. AMORA. I
built all of this. To fix what I
did.

No tears. Past crying. Arrived at this room twenty years ago.
Every step since toward this moment.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
Everything the Mirror does. Every
seduction. Every false comfort.
That is her compassion. Weaponized.

Nora. Still. The hollow holds. Processing.

NORA
It helped me decode.
(beat)
It was not helping me. Was reaching
for you.

A woman standing in front of the machine that ate her sister.

Jace beside her. Chrome at his temple. His one good eye on
Riven.

He understands before Nora does. Because Jace knows what it
is to carry a dead person's weight. He knows what Riven is
about to do.

INT. GARDEN CORE - CENTRAL CHAMBER - CONTINUOUS

Nora moves to the chamber's edge. Where the amber column
roots into the floor, the relay path splits and feeds the
walls. The door the charge has to pass through.

She kneels. Presses the cracked lens flat against the living
architecture. Her other hand to the port at her neck.

The system feels it. Analog glass it cannot read. A clean port it cannot corrupt. It pushes back -- a pressure behind her eyes, the same weight as a decode.

She holds. The path stays open.

NORA
(to Riven, not looking up)
Set the fire. I have the door.

Riven walks to the root node.

The pendant in her left fist. The destruction charge in her right.

Each step heavier than the last. The amber light warming her face. Her sister's light.

AMARA (V.O.)
(from the root node)
Stay with me.

Riven stops. One step from the node.

The voice of her sister. Seventeen. Afraid.

Asking her to stay the way she asked twenty years ago in a hospital room. Monitors. Wires. A window facing a parking lot.

Riven shakes. The charge in her grip.

She lifts it toward the base of the node. Stops. Cannot place it.

Then she pulls back. The charge against her chest. The pendant pressing into her palm.

AMARA (V.O.)
You promised you would fix it.

RIVEN
I know.

She tries again. Steps forward. The amber light pulses faster. Warmer. The closest thing to an embrace the system can produce.

Riven's jaw locks. She kneels at the base of the node. Places the charge on the floor.

She stays. Does not let go.

AMARA (V.O.)
If you do this I am gone.

RIVEN
You have been gone.

Her voice breaks. One word. Gone.

RIVEN (CONT'D)
For twenty years.

Silence.

The amber light slows. The frantic pulse easing.

And then Amara's voice changes.

Not the Mirror's preservation. Not the system fighting to survive. Something beneath it. Older. The girl before the machine took her.

AMARA (V.O.)
(different - steady,
clear)
Riven.

The same name. Said the way Amara said it when she was alive. Not afraid. Not pleading.

The amber light steadies. Still. The neural patterns stop cycling.

The system screams beneath the silence. The Mirror wants to live.

But Amara's pattern, the human core, holds the light still.

Permission.

Riven reads it. Sister to sister.

Her eyes stay on the root node.

Looks at the amber light. Her sister's neural pattern. The last trace.

RIVEN
I am sorry I could not save you. I
am sorry I let them use you.

Riven activates the charge.

The root lunges to reroute. To heal around the breach the way it always has.

It cannot. Nora has the path open. The charge runs all the way down.

The root node screams. Not Amara. The system. The architecture tearing itself apart as the destruction sequence begins.

The chamber convulses. Chrome and amber tearing apart. The light fracturing.

Riven stays.

The system's death reaches for her. The collapse consuming the architecture outward from the node.

It takes her the way it took her sister. Into the machine. Into the ending.

The path collapses with the root that needed holding. The lens snaps back against Nora's chest, the hold gone. The recoil throws her to the chamber floor.

Her fingers open.

The pendant falls. Silver bird. One wing. Spinning in amber light that is already dying.

Nora catches it.

The metal is warm.

Riven is gone.

INT. GARDEN CORE - COLLAPSING ARCHITECTURE - CONTINUOUS

The system dies.

Relay hubs bursting. The cathedral of memory folding inward. Archived voices stopping. One by one.

On Nora's HUD: HUB FREQUENCY 773 / STATUS: RELEASED.

One hub among fifteen. One girl among millions.

Nora does not slow down.

The framework collapsing.

Somewhere in the architecture: Ilya.

The chrome threads in her uniform pulse. Erratic. The system she wired herself into is dying and it is taking her managed grief with it.

She falls to her knees.

Not from impact. From feeling.

Twenty years of processed grief. The loss her child's death carved into her. The hole the system filled with numbness and called it healing.

The numbness is gone.

The hole is back.

Mina. Seventeen. The morning Ilya found her.

The system held that morning for twenty years. Held it still. Held it silent. Let Ilya walk and work and order and believe.

Now the system is dying. And the morning is here.

Hub seven-seven-three goes dark. The frequency Nora entered.
The hub that held Mina.

The numbness lifts.

Ilya screams.

Not words. Not a name.

The sound a person makes when twenty years of nothing breaks
open and what floods back is the worst thing that ever
happened to them.

The chrome threads go dark. One by one. The integration
failing.

Ilya on the floor. The architecture collapsing around her.
She does not try to move.

Standing is over for her.

Not without the numbness. Not without the lie.

She dies the way her daughter died. Consumed by what she
could not carry alone.

The chrome at her temple catches the last amber light. Then
goes dark.

INT. GARDEN CORE - COLLAPSING ARCHITECTURE - CONTINUOUS

The architecture is dying. The lattice fracturing overhead.

Nora runs. Jace beside her. His chrome arm dragging. The
conversion at his cheekbone.

On her HUD: RESET: 02:11:04.

The Mirror makes its final offer.

Not through the architecture. Through her port. The clean
channel. Eli's old address.

THE MIRROR (V.O.)
(through the port)
Stay.

Nora stops.

THE MIRROR (V.O.)
I can give him back to you. Every
morning. Every word. The apartment.
The lens before it cracked.

The collapsing architecture stills around her. The Mirror
holding one last pocket of stability. One last room.

Inside it: Eli. Standing. Warm. The way he was before the morning she found him on the floor.

One shoe on. One off.

His right hand on the camera.

Wrong hand.

Eli was left-handed. Every morning for three years, the camera in his left grip, the shutter-click she heard through the wall before coffee. The system built him from data that mapped his face and voice and fingerprints but never watched him work.

He speaks. Her name. Complete. Warm. A finished sentence in a voice that never finished sentences before coffee.

The hollow cracks. Not the shoe -- the shoe is right. The hand. The voice. The things the system built from data instead of mornings, close enough to fool anyone who did not wake up next to him for three years.

She feels it. Since the second funeral. She feels it hit.

NORA

No.

Not loud. Not defiant.

NORA (CONT'D)

No clean versions. No mercy rewrites.

She looks at the image of Eli. The system's perfect copy. Whole. Unbroken. The cracked lens in his grip made smooth.

NORA (CONT'D)

Real or broken. It is mine.

The image dissolves. The pocket collapses. The architecture resumes its dying.

Nora runs.

INT. GARDEN CORE - EXIT CORRIDOR - CONTINUOUS

The corridor ahead is collapsing. Chrome lattice falling.

Jace stumbles.

Chrome arm seizes. The conversion has reached his jaw. Left eye silver. Right still brown. Still his.

Falls.

It slides from his chrome grip. Across the floor. Away.

JACE
(strained)
Nora.

She turns.

He is on the floor. The chrome spreading. Face half-metal.
Remaining eye finding her.

The tether between them: failing. His side of the channel
disintegrating.

JACE (CONT'D)
Go.

Nora stands in a collapsing corridor with the pendant of a
dead girl in one fist and the cracked lens in the other.

The hollow says go. The hollow says survive.

The hollow does not love.

Nora does.

Kneels.

Her palm on his chrome jaw. The metal warm. The skin beneath
it still there. Still him.

NORA
If you drift.

The words. The vow. Spoken first in a recovery alcove after
Eli was gone.

Spoken now in a collapsing cathedral with the system dying
around them.

NORA (CONT'D)
I will pull.

She grabs his remaining hand. Not chrome. Skin. His fingers
close around hers.

Through the tether, Nora staggers. Not her pain. Riven's.
Twenty years of it flooding the connection.

Jace catches her arm.

Nora shakes her head. Stays standing. The cost of what Riven
is doing pouring through her port.

The tether flares. Not the system's tether. Not hardware. Her
voice in his skull and his grip in her palm and the decision
to stay.

The root signal dies. The chrome loses instruction. Nora's
tether catches what is left of him.

The chrome stops.

No reversal. No healing. But it stops. At his jaw. At his eye. The conversion holding.

Half his face chrome. Half skin. The border drawn.

Jace breathes.

She pulls him up.

He reaches for the recorder. Chrome fingers closing on analog plastic. The grip holds.

JACE
Still here.

NORA
Still here.

They run.

The architecture collapsing behind them. The root node gone. The relay hubs dark. The voices silent.

Amara's voice. One last thread. Moving through the dying system.

Not a scream. A whisper. The same steady voice that gave Riven permission.

Joining the silence. Candle into dark.

Then nothing.

On Nora's HUD: RESET: 01:44:22.

Ahead: daylight.

CUT TO BLACK.

EXT. GARDEN CORE - SURFACE ACCESS - DAWN

Daylight.

Nora and Jace come through the access tunnel at a dead run. Chrome lattice collapsing behind them.

Not explosion. Cessation. A heart stopping mid-beat.

They clear the threshold.

Behind them: the last relay hub goes dark. The cathedral of memory folds one final time.

The hum that has lived beneath the city for twenty years dies mid-frequency.

Then nothing.

Sunlight. Unprocessed. Not chrome. Not amber. The color of a world with no filter on it.

Nora stands in the light.

The pendant in her left hand. Still warm from Riven's body. The lens in her right. Cracked. Eli's.

Jace beside her. Chrome arm hanging. Recorder in his grip. Tova's.

Three objects. Three dead people. Two survivors.

Nora's port goes clear.

The channel that carried the Mirror, carried Ilya, carried Eli's residue through 240 days of refusal. Silent.

For the first time since she woke up alone in their apartment, her hardware holds nothing but her own signal.

She does not know what to do with that.

Jace leans against the access wall. Chrome eye catching sunlight, splitting it wrong. The remaining eye finds her.

JACE
(wrecked)
We are outside.

Not a statement. A fact he needs to hear himself say.

Nora looks at the pendant. The silver bird with one wing. Tarnished. Handmade.

A dead girl's gift to a sister who carried it for twenty years and died holding it.

She unclasps the cord on her lens. Threads the pendant beside it. Two objects on one leather strap. Eli and Amara. Purpose and origin.

Puts the cord back around her neck.

Both of them against her sternum.

EXT. / INT. VARIOUS - GLOBAL - DAWN

Tokyo. A man in a SoulSync chair. The screen goes dark. His session ends mid-sentence.

He opens his eyes. They are wet. He does not understand why.

Paris. A woman standing in a memorial kiosk. The interface dies. The holographic face of her son dissolves in front of her.

She reaches into her coat. Finds a matchbook. Strikes it.

Real fire. Real light. She holds it until it burns her fingers.

Lagos. Two strangers on a bench outside a grief center. The center's lights go out. The sign goes dark.

One touches the other's wrist. Neither speaks.

New York. A mother holding a photograph. The SoulSync billboard behind her cycles once and dies.

She presses the photograph to her chest. Her mouth opens. No sound comes. The grief is hers again.

EXT. CITY STREETS - DAWN

The city. The billboards dark. The kiosks dead. The memorial garden bench empty.

The polish gone.

The city is ugly and real and the people in it are standing in the wreckage of a promise that was never going to hold.

Nora and Jace walk. Not running. Walking. The first time they have moved without a countdown driving them.

On Nora's HUD: RESET: 00:00:03.

She watches the numbers fall.

RESET: 00:00:02.

RESET: 00:00:01.

RESET: 00:00:00 // ABORTED.

The HUD goes dark.

The port is hardware now. No system. No countdown. No warnings. No voices. Done.

Nora stops walking.

Jace stops beside her.

Rain.

Not dramatic. Not symbolic. The sky opens and it rains.

The way it rained before SoulSync existed. Before the Mirror. Before Amora learned to hold grief so people would not have to.

Water on her face. On the pendant. On the cracked lens. On Jace's chrome arm and the recorder in his grip.

Real water on real skin.

Since the morning she found Eli on the kitchen floor, the world is not asking her to choose between feeling and surviving, and the relief of that is so large she does not have a name for it yet.

Nora lifts her face to it. Eyes closed. The rain filling the silence the system left behind.

When she opens her eyes, the world is blurred and wet and imperfect and there is no interface to correct it.

NORA
(to no one)
It rained.

Two words. Present tense. The first weather report of the world after.

No answer needed. He holds the recorder against his chest. She holds the pendant and the lens against hers.

They stand in the rain.

The city drips. The screens stay dark. Somewhere, a woman strikes a match and the flame is the only light that works.

CUT TO BLACK.

INT. APARTMENT - MORNING

TITLE CARD: THREE WEEKS LATER

A different apartment. Not the one she shared with Eli.

Small. Two rooms. Bare walls. A window that faces east.

Morning light. Unfiltered.

The pendant and lens hang from a hook by the door. Leather cord looped twice. The silver bird catching the light.

Routine. Like shoes.

The cord against her neck. Both objects against her sternum. She does not adjust them.

Kitchen counter. Two mugs. One clean. One used.

Jace at the table. Chrome arm on the surface. The conversion permanent. Silver from jaw to fingertip. His remaining eye on the recorder.

He presses play.

Tova's voice. Tinny. Analog. Mid-sentence.

He rewinds. Plays it again. The same sentence.

Not searching for something. Listening.

Nora pours water into the clean mug. Sets it beside him. His chrome fingers find the mug.

She stands behind him. Palm on his shoulder. The one that is still skin.

Three seconds.

She lets go.

NORA
I am going.

JACE
(not looking up)
I know.

She picks up a bag from the floor. Camera equipment inside. The weight familiar.

At the door she pauses. Touches the pendant through her shirt.

Does not look back.

Leaves.

EXT. CITY STREETS - MORNING

The city without its filter.

The SoulSync billboards are dark. Some have been stripped for parts. Some have been painted over. Murals in their place. Crude. Human.

The memorial kiosks stand empty. The holographic ports dead. Someone has put flowers in one. Real flowers. Wilting.

Nora moves.

Port scar visible. Healed but present. She does not cover it.

She passes a bench. A man sitting alone. Holding a phone. Looking at a photograph on the screen. His mouth tight.

He sits with it.

His grief is his.

She keeps walking.

A park. Where the memorial garden was. The holographic flowers are gone. Real ones growing in the beds now. Uneven. Patchy.

A woman kneeling in the dirt. Planting something. Fingers black with soil.

The woman looks up as Nora passes. Nods. Nothing else.

Nora nods back.

She sits on a bench at the edge of the park. Opens her bag.

The camera. Not Eli's. Hers. New. Cheap. The lens she threads onto it is his. The cracked one. The fracture line still splitting the glass.

She lifts it. Left hand on the body. The grip she learned from watching him.

Through the crack: the woman in the garden. Fingers in the dirt. Real grief making real things grow.

The shutter clicks. She advances the frame.

Through the crack: the empty kiosk with real flowers in its dead port.

Through the crack: the painted mural where the billboard was.

Through the crack: the man on the bench. Phone. Photograph. Face doing what faces do without correction.

Click. Click. Click.

Eli's lens. Nora's eye. His mission in her grip. Her connection.

INT. APARTMENT - EVENING

The light through the east window is gone. The apartment is warm with west light now.

Nora enters.

Hangs the pendant and lens on the hook. The cord swinging once. Still.

Jace on the floor. Back against the wall. The recorder beside him. Not playing.

Chrome arm across his knee. Human palm around a cup. The mug she poured this morning. Empty now.

Looks up.

Brown eye. Chrome eye. Both finding her.

JACE
You were gone a while.

NORA
There was a lot to see.

She sits beside him. The wall cold behind her. Their shoulders touching the way they touched in the corridor. In the cathedral. In the rain.

Rain starts. Soft against the window. The sound of it filling the room the way the system used to.

Jace tilts his head. The chrome side catching the last light.

JACE
(low)
If you forget.

NORA
I will remind you.

JACE
If you drift.

NORA
I will pull.

Rain on the window.

She does not reach for him. He does not reach for her.

They are already close enough.

Streetlamps. Storefronts. The glow of a world remembering how to work without a system telling it what to feel.

Nora closes her eyes.

When she opens them, the rain has not stopped, the room is dark and the man beside her is still there.

Still here.

FADE TO BLACK.

THE END.